

BRICS: WHEN DELHI SLEEPS, NDMC'S SANITATION CREWS STAY AWAKE **P3**



PUNJAB: PILOT APPOINTED GENERAL SECRETARY IN-CHARGE **P6**

'DIDN'T EXPECT PEOPLE WOULD FEEL SO MUCH FOR SWEET' **P12**



SEVERAL STUDENTS FEARED TRAPPED

Student hostel caves in, 5 dead

Delhi CM orders magisterial inquiry; building owner booked

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE & SHIVANGI SHUKLA

New Delhi, September 6

A five-storey building used as a student hostel in South Delhi's Satya Niketan caved in on Sunday afternoon, killing at least five people and leaving between 15 and 20 others feared trapped as rescue teams worked through the night to pull survivors from the rubble.

The structure came down around 1.30 pm in a cramped lane near Delhi University's South Campus, close to the Nanakpura Gurdwara. The building, run under the name Hostel Daze, housed a boys' PG and was packed with students who study at Motilal Nehru College, Atma Ram Sanatan Dharm College and Sri Venkateswara College, most of them from Kerala, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh. Locals estimated that anywhere between 30 and 50 people could have been inside when it fell, though officials never confirmed a firm number. Locals also claimed that



Police personnel on site after a five-storey building collapsed at Satya Niketan area, in New Delhi, Sunday **PTI**

they were even getting calls from those who were trapped inside.

Accounts of the build-

ing's age varied. Municipal officials described it as a nearly 30-year-old structure, built as a ground-plus-

four block on just 55 square yards of land in a resettlement colony where permission had been granted

only for a ground-plus-one unit. Many students and neighbours, however, said the building was closer to

TAKEAWAYS

- » Authorities could not confirm the number trapped
- » Locals estimated 30 to 50 people were inside
- » NDRF deployed 70 personnel across two teams
- » Canine squads and life detectors searched the rubble
- » Oxygen cylinders were lowered beneath the debris
- » Police booked building owner and others over collapse
- » Renovation work was reportedly underway before collapse
- » MCD said building exceeded its sanctioned construction limits

50 or 60 years old. Officials said sanction violations of this kind were common in the area, where scores of houses have been converted into PG accommodations for students.

The death toll climbed through **CONTINUED ON P4**

India supports UN map reforms, seeks accurate depiction of J&K, Ladakh

Says sovereignty position non-negotiable

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 6

India on Sunday said a UN-initiated proposed world map must depict Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh in accordance with the country's official map, and any "inaccurate" or "misleading" representation will be unacceptable.

India's assertion came two days after it voted in favour of a UN General Assembly resolution aimed at correcting the world map to promote a more accurate representation of continental landmasses.

The resolution titled "Correct the Map: Rebalancing Global Cartographic Representation and Promoting Equitable Representation of the World's Regions, Particularly Africa" was adopted on September 4. The US had opposed it.

External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said India highlighted that the resolution does not constitute endorsement of any spe-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » India backed UN resolution on accurate world maps
- » UN General Assembly adopted resolution on September 4
- » Resolution promotes equal-area cartographic representation
- » US opposed the UN resolution
- » Resolution received 164 votes in favour

cific map, projection or depiction of national boundaries.

"India voted in favour of the resolution and also made an explanation of vote stressing on the underlying principle of promoting equal-area cartographic representation," he said while responding to a media query on the issue.

"India's sovereign territory, including the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, must be depicted in accordance with **CONTINUED ON P4**

Briefs

India emerges as key diesel supplier to EU

NEW DELHI: India supplied about 60 per cent of diesel transiting Bab-el-Mandeb to Europe in August, with flows near 2,00,000 barrels per day, Vortexa data showed. Russian exports remained depressed at 1,50,000 barrels per day, while US shipments fell 35 per cent to 3,50,000 barrels per day. India's crude imports also dropped to 3.8 million barrels per day, from 4.8 million a year earlier. **SEE P11**

Centre sells 4,000 tonnes of buffer onions

NEW DELHI: The Centre has sold around 4,000 tonnes of buffer onion in 17 cities over the first 10 days of its subsidised retail intervention aimed at bringing down high prices, Consumer Affairs Secretary Nidhi Khare said on Sunday. **CONTINUED ON P4**

ISRO says it will not be privatised

NEW DELHI: ISRO on Sunday said it would neither be privatised nor lose importance, following concerns raised by nine employee associations on September 4 over remarks by IN-SPACE chairperson Pawan Goenka. ISRO said industry would scale mature systems while it focuses on advanced R&D and strategic missions. Goenka said ISRO remains the sector's "bedrock." **SEE P6**

Spurious liquor claims 11 lives in MP's Sagar; 35 hospitalised

Govt suspends, attaches Excise officials; orders high-level probe; UP liquor link under scanner; outlets sealed

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA
Bhopal, September 6

At least 11 people have died since Saturday night, while nearly 35 others have been hospitalised after allegedly consuming suspected spurious liquor in Madhya Pradesh's Sagar district.

However, the death toll remained disputed, with state Congress chief Jitu Patwari claiming that 15 people had died in the incident. Sagar Collector Pratibha Pal confirmed 10 deaths, while Banda BJP MLA Virendra Lodhi put the toll at 11.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav described the deaths in the Banda-Shahgarh area as "extremely sad and



unfortunate" and ordered strict action against those responsible, along with a detailed probe. Hours later, the state government suspended three key Excise officials and attached another official to Excise headquarters, besides ordering a high-level inquiry into

the tragedy.

The Chief Minister also instructed Deputy Chief Minister Jagdish Devda, who holds the Excise portfolio, and the district in-charge minister to immediately visit the affected area and monitor the situation. Yadav is currently on **CONTINUED ON P4**

Death toll reaches 1,344 as Nepal struggles to identify flood victims

MPOST BUREAU
Kathmandu, September 6

Rescuers in Nepal continued searching for nearly 5,000 missing people on Sunday, 11 days after devastating floods swept through large parts of the country, killing at least 1,344 people and leaving authorities struggling to identify more than 1,000 bodies.

Nepal Police said 4,999 people, including 589 foreign nationals, remained missing, while about 13,400 people had been rescued. The disaster began on August 26 after an ice-rock avalanche near the Nepal-Tibet border triggered a massive surge of water and debris through the Bhotekoshi River, destroying homes, roads, bridges, vehicles and hydropower infrastructure.



At least 43 people were killed on the Chinese side and more than 500 remained missing in Tibet, according to Chinese media reports.

Among the bodies recovered in Nepal were at least 85 children. Around 500 bodies were found with parts missing, making identification difficult. Chitwan recorded the high-

est number of recovered bodies at 362, while bodies were also found in Nawalparasi East and West, Nuwakot, Rasuwa, Gorkha, Dhading and Tanahun.

The National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority said only 98 bodies had been identified and handed over to families. Police have begun **CONTINUED ON P4**

Minor CJP student activist seeks police protection, claims stones pelted at home

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 6

A controversy involving the alleged assault of a 38-year-old man during protests at Delhi's Jantar Mantar has widened into a dispute over the safety of his family and the authenticity of social media posts, after his minor daughter alleged that their house was surrounded and attacked, while she separately denied that some posts attributed to her were genuine.

The student activist, who has sought protection from the Delhi and Ghaziabad police, alleged in videos posted on X on Saturday night that people she described **CONTINUED ON P4**

Centre appoints chief justices to eight high courts

Twenty-five Collegium recommendations for appointing HC judges pending with Centre

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, September 6

The government has appointed chief justices to eight high courts, days after the Supreme Court Collegium recommended their names, while 25 other recommendations for high court judge appointments remain pending with the Centre, including the case of advocate Saurabh Kirpal, whose name has been awaiting a final decision for nearly nine years. The appointments come amid a continuing process to fill vacancies across the higher judiciary, with 304 of the 1,122 sanctioned high court judge posts currently vacant.

Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal announced the appointments in a post on X. Justice Valluri Kameswar Rao of the Delhi High Court has been appointed Chief Justice of the Patna High Court, while Justice Ravindra V Ghuge of the Bombay High Court will become Chief Justice of the Calcutta High Court.

Justice Sanjay Kumar Agrawal of the Chhattisgarh High Court has been appointed Chief Justice of the Rajasthan High Court. Justice Mahesh Chandra Tripathi of the Allahabad High Court will head the Bombay High Court. Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra of the Punjab and Haryana High Court has been appointed Chief Justice of that court.

The other appointments are Justice Krishna Ram Mohapatra of the Orissa High Court as Chief Justice of the Chhattisgarh **CONTINUED ON P4**

5.72 CRORE HAVE ZERO BALANCE

Every fourth Jan Dhan account inoperative: RTI

MPOST BUREAU
Jaipur, September 6

Nearly one in four bank accounts opened under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) is currently classified as inoperative, while nearly 5.72 crore accounts have no balance, according to data obtained under the Right to Information Act.

The Department of Financial Services, Ministry of Finance, said in an RTI response dated September 1 that India had 59,03,74,907 PMJDY accounts with a combined balance of Rs 3,15,179.90 crore as of August 12, 2026. The response was issued to activist Chandra Shekhar Gaur.



Of the total accounts, 32.89 crore belong to women, including transgender account holders, while 26.14 crore are held by men. The data showed that 5,72,35,490 accounts had zero balance. Another 15,36,77,009 accounts were classified as inoperative. Uttar Pradesh reported

the largest number of zero-balance accounts at 95.92 lakh, followed by Bihar with 62.35 lakh, West Bengal with 37.20 lakh, Assam with 36.30 lakh and Maharashtra with 36.04 lakh.

The state also topped the list for inoperative accounts, with 3.23 crore such accounts. Bihar fol-

KEY POINTS

- » Jan Dhan accounts cross 59 crore nationwide
- » Total Jan Dhan deposits exceed Rs 3.15 lakh crore
- » Data covers accounts as of August 12, 2026
- » Women hold 32.89 crore Jan Dhan accounts
- » Men hold 26.14 crore Jan Dhan accounts
- » Uttar Pradesh leads zero-balance accounts with 95.92 lakh
- » Bihar has 62.35 lakh zero-balance accounts

lowed with 1.59 crore, Madhya Pradesh with 1.35 crore, West Bengal with 1.02 crore and Maharashtra with 97.94 lakh.

Uttar Pradesh had the highest overall number of Jan Dhan accounts at 10.51 crore. Bihar had 7.01 crore, West Bengal 5.73 crore, Rajasthan 3.87 crore and

Maharashtra 3.85 crore.

Launched in August 2014 as the National Mission for Financial Inclusion, PMJDY seeks to provide households with access to banking services, financial literacy and social security benefits through at least one basic bank account. **CONTINUED ON P4**

Printed and Published by Jaiyendra Kumar Sharma on behalf of Front Row Media Pvt. Ltd. and printed at The Indian Express Pvt. Ltd., A-8, Sector-7, Noida-201 301 (U.P.) and published from First Floor, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002. Editor: Durbar Ganguly. Email: editor@millenniumpost.in, Tel. No. 011-47777500. Kolkata office: Room No 1.15th Floor, Chatterjee International Centre, 33A Jawaharlal Nehru Road, Kolkata 700071 West Bengal. Siliguri Office: Techno India Group Zonal Office G-212, 2nd Floor Office Block - City Centre Matigara District Darjeeling Pin - 734010 Phone- 0353- 2576321

BRICS: When Delhi sleeps, NDMC’s sanitation crews stay awake

ANAMTA FATIMA
New Delhi, September 6

As New Delhi prepares to receive BRICS delegates from September 8-9, the city’s usual morning sanitation routine has been extended into the night. The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has stepped up cleaning operations across its jurisdiction, deploying additional workers and machines to ensure that roads, markets and

public spaces are cleared before the city wakes up. The intensified operations began on September 4, with nearly 300 sanitation workers and 10 Mechanical Road Sweepers deployed during the night. Teams are tasked with sweeping roads, lifting accumulated waste and emptying bins and trolleys. Early-morning pressure-jet cleaning follows, allowing the morning shift to focus on finishing work and

addressing fresh sanitation requirements. Major markets are being cleaned three times a day morning, evening and night while key roads and stretches are under continuous supervision. Machines take centre stage The civic body has added 15 Gobbler machines during the day to collect scattered waste and litter. Eleven pressure-jetting machines have also been

deployed for deep cleaning of roads, footpaths, market areas and other public spaces. Manual intervention, however, remains central to the exercise, particularly in crowded markets and pedestrian stretches. Door-to-door waste collection has been intensified in high-foot-fall areas, with trolley lifting organised across three shifts. The workforce has been divided into three shifts, with around 120 per-

sonnel deployed in the evening and the rest during the morning. Supervisory officials and Palika Sahayaks have been placed on 24x7 availability, with leave cancelled or restricted wherever necessary. A civic appeal NDMC Chairman Manoj Kumar Dwivedi has urged residents, shopkeepers, offices, hotels and transport operators to contribute to the effort by keeping

areas around their premises clean and ensuring courteous service. The objective, he said, was not merely to prepare the city for an international gathering but to offer visitors a glimpse of a “beautiful, clean, honest India”. For the NDMC, the BRICS Summit has thus turned cleanliness into a continuous exercise one that begins after dark and continues through the day.



Road, power... works get push in Shalimar Bagh and Pitampura

ANAMTA FATIMA
New Delhi, September 6

In a recent push to upgrade neighbourhood-level infrastructure, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta inaugurated several development works across Shalimar Bagh and Pitampura on Sunday, including a new road link, underground power cabling, sanitation facilities, waste management infrastructure and park beautification. The projects are aimed at improving everyday infrastructure, sanitation, road connectivity and public spaces in the area. Gupta inaugurated the construction of a new school building in BB Block, Shalimar Bagh, aimed at strengthening educational infrastructure for local students. In AF Block, work was launched to replace open overhead conductors with underground electricity cables. A similar project was launched along the main road of C&D Block, Shalimar Bagh, to make the power network safer and more organised. The Chief Minister also launched construction of a road connecting Shri Guru Gobind Singh College in Pitampura with Ring Road. The project, estimated to cost around Rs 2.84 crore,

“THE DELHI GOVT’S AIM IS NOT TO LIMIT DEVELOPMENT TO LARGE PROJECTS, BUT TO PROVIDE BETTER FACILITIES TO EVERY STREET, EVERY COLONY AND EVERY CITIZEN

is expected to improve connectivity and ease commuting for residents. Sanitation infrastructure also figured prominently in the development push. Gupta inaugurated a newly constructed toilet block at Nehru Camp in Haiderpur and a modern waste compactor at SP-TP Block, Pitampura, aimed at strengthening waste management. She also inaugurated beautification and development works in three parks in YP Block and 10 parks in WP Block, providing residents with improved green and recreational spaces. Emphasising the government’s focus on neighbourhood-level infrastructure, Gupta said, “The Delhi government’s aim is not to limit development to large projects, but to provide better facilities to every street, every colony and every citizen.”

TARGETS 10,000 STARTUPS, 4 LAKH JOBS Startup push: Delhi govt seeks industry inputs on new policy

ANAMTA FATIMA
New Delhi, September 6

With Delhi looking to expand its startup ecosystem, the government on Sunday held a roundtable with leading entrepreneurs, investors and industry experts to seek inputs on its proposed Startup & Incubation Policy, 2026, including suggestions on easing regulations, improving access to workspace and attracting private investment.



A key suggestion from industry representatives was to position Delhi as the country’s “Deregulation Capital”, with participants calling for measures to make it easier for startups to operate and scale. Suggestions included increasing the availability of land and workspaces, rationalising Floor Area Ratio (FAR) and circle rates, and setting up a permanent regulatory help desk staffed by domain experts. Participants also proposed that

the government become a major early customer for startups and develop public AI infrastructure and data sandboxes for deep-tech and government technology firms. Priority sectors suggested included Artificial Intelligence, FinTech, AgriTech, Defence and Aerospace, DeepTech, GovTech, LegalTech, EdTech and MedTech. On funding, industry representatives suggested structuring the proposed Rs 407.5-crore fund as a

Fund of Funds, which could use government capital to attract larger private investments into startups. The roundtable also discussed measures to encourage women entrepreneurs, including a dedicated women-founder category and ring-fenced funding. Other suggestions included linking ITIs more closely with industry needs, creating advisory cells in educational institutions, building mentorship networks and giving students greater academic flexibility to pursue entrepreneurship. Gupta said Delhi’s youth, educational institutions, technological capabilities and large market gave the city an advantage in building a startup ecosystem. Sood said the government aimed to “support and encourage more than 10,000 startups during its tenure and create employment opportunities for more than 4 lakh youth through these startups.”

Delhi steps up pollution awareness drive

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 6

With the pollution season approaching, the Delhi government on Sunday launched a citywide awareness campaign seeking to involve residents, industries, institutions and community groups in measures to curb air pollution. The Information, Education and Communication (IEC) campaign, titled “Saath Nibhayein, Pradushan Ghataayein”, will run from September 2026 to March 2027 and focus on awareness, behavioural change and compliance alongside regulatory and enforcement measures. Environment Minister

Manjinder Singh Sirsa said government action alone would not be sufficient to address Delhi’s air pollution challenge. “The fight for clean air cannot be won by the Government alone. Every citizen, every institution and every stakeholder has an important role to play,” he said. Led by the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC), the campaign will involve schools and colleges, industries, resident welfare associations, markets, construction stakeholders, bulk waste generators, farmers and vehicle owners. The outreach will include workshops, community programmes, sensitisation



drives and field-level activities, along with newspaper advertisements, hoardings, posters, radio jingles, street plays and booklets. As part of the industrial outreach, DPCC has already conducted district-level workshops in industrial areas on Online Continuous Emission Monitoring Systems (OCEMS), air pol-

lution control devices, compliance requirements for diesel generator sets and other pollution-control measures. Sirsa said industries and commercial establishments had an important role in improving air quality. “Development and environmental responsibility must go hand in hand,” he said, adding that the campaign would seek to promote compliance and cleaner practices. The campaign has also begun with activities by various departments and organisations. NDMC conducted awareness activities with sanitation workers, while NGO Chintan held training sessions for house-

keeping staff at Lodhi Garden and Chanakya Mall under the Delhi Ko Kude Se Azadi campaign. The Transport Department’s outreach focused on pollution under vehicle fitness and PUC compliance, timely servicing, responsible disposal of end-of-life vehicles, cleaner fuels and electric vehicles. The Delhi Traffic Police also conducted a road-safety awareness programme involving 300 students. The government said the campaign would continue with activities across Delhi over the coming months, with the focus on making pollution control a shared responsibility rather than an enforcement-only exercise.

Metro window reels draw DMRC warning

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 6

A social media trend involving passengers filming videos with mobile phones attached to Delhi Metro train windows has prompted a warning from the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), which said such filming could pose risks to commuters and damage devices. The trend has gained traction on platforms including Instagram, with creators using mounts to secure their phones to the glass of moving Metro coaches while recording reels. Some videos are staged to give the impression that a creator has left a phone behind as a train departs. According to DMRC, several such videos have recently surfaced online, prompting the corporation to issue an advisory direct-

ing content creators to stop recording such clips inside Metro premises. “This act can cause inconvenience or even injury to other passengers and can damage the mobile phone devices of the users,” DMRC said. The corporation also warned that it would take action against creators found shooting such content on Metro premises. The trend, which reportedly gained popularity overseas before being replicated by creators in India, has produced a wave of similar videos across Delhi Metro stations. One video by a local creator reportedly crossed 135 million views, encouraging others to recreate the format. DMRC has urged creators to refrain from such shoots, citing passenger safety and the possibility of inconvenience or damage arising from the practice.

CLEARs 5,000 PENDING LAB REPORTS Delhi excise dept auctions over 2,000 seized vehicles

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 6

The excise department of Delhi government has auctioned over 2,000 seized vehicles, fetching Rs 5 crore in revenue, and cleared over 5,000 pending chemical analysis reports bringing the backlog of its type to zero. The auction of vehicles seized under the Delhi Excise Act freed up space at police station premises and public land, a Delhi CMO statement said. Delhi government is taking concrete steps to make the administration more effective and functional, it said. More than 2,000 vehicles seized under the Delhi Excise Act had been lying for a long time outside police stations and on adjoining public land. To address the issue, the department undertook a

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The auction of vehicles seized under the Delhi Excise Act freed up space at police station premises and public land
- » Delhi government is taking concrete steps to make the administration more effective and functional

special disposal drive under the Delhi Excise Act. As part of the exercise, the process of seizure and public auction was streamlined and more than 2,000 vehicles were auctioned. The department is also looking to dispose of the remaining seized vehicles. More than 5,000 old chemical analysis reports related to police cases had been pending at the labora-

tory, which have been disposed of, bringing the active backlog down to zero. Earlier, laboratory reports on seized liquor samples could take years to arrive. This often delayed the related police investigations and subsequently affected the legal process the CMO said. Now, the lab staff have been recruited against posts that had remained vacant for a long time, while the modernisation of the laboratory is also under way. Faster access to chemical analysis reports is expected to directly benefit enforcement of excise laws and police investigations. According to the department, a faster testing system will strengthen excise enforcement and help develop an effective deterrent against the smuggling of illicit liquor.

Seven artists honoured with Legends Awards

SHIVANGI SHUKLA
New Delhi, September 6

Bharatanatyam gurus V.P. Dhananjayan and Shanta Dhananjayan, sitar maestro Ustad Shahid Parvez Khan and four other eminent artists were honoured with the Legends of India Lifetime Achievement Awards 2026 by Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar T.S. Sandhu at a ceremony in New Delhi. The awards recognised the artists’ contributions across different Indian art forms. The Dhananjayans were honoured for their contribution to Bharatanatyam, while Ustad Shahid Parvez Khan received the award for his mastery of the sitar and Hindustani classical music. Shri T.H. Vinayakram was recognised for his contribution to Carnatic classical music, Shri Margi Madhu for India’s theat-

rical traditions and Shri K.S. Radhakrishnan for his contribution to Indian sculpture. The ceremony at the IIC Multipurpose Hall was attended by Chairman, Festivals & Awards, Legends of India, Ambassador Lalit Mansingh, Founder Chairman, Legends of India, Shri Dipayan Mazumdar, the awardees and other guests. Speaking on the occasion, Sandhu said the recognition was also about the cultural traditions represented by the awardees and the work that has gone into sustaining them over decades. He said India’s classical music, dance, theatre and visual arts carry the country’s history, imagination and collective memory and can serve as a means of dialogue across differences of language and background.

Briefs

Ceiling plaster fall kills 15-year-old

NEW DELHI: A 15-year-old boy died after cement plaster from the ceiling of a room fell on him while he was asleep with his twin brother in northeast Delhi’s Welcome area on Sunday, police said. The incident took place at around 5 am near Qabristan Pulia in Welcome, they said. Police received information about the incident at around 7 am. The boy was shifted by his family members to Kailash Deepak Hospital in Anand Vihar, where doctors declared him brought dead. His twin brother also sustained injuries in the incident and is undergoing treatment at a local nursing home in Welcome.

Man stabbed to death

NEW DELHI: A man was allegedly stabbed to death in east Delhi’s New Ashok Nagar area early Sunday, police sources said. The incident took place near a Durga temple in front of a local MLA’s office, they said. According to preliminary information, a security guard at a nearby housing society told police that he saw two men attacking the victim with a knife at around 5 am. The guard tried to intervene and drive the attackers away, but they allegedly assaulted him and also attempted to attack him.

India-France relations have reached new heights: PM Modi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 6

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said India-France relations have reached new heights and this strategic partnership is particularly special because it rests on the solid foundation of long-standing cultural and political ties.

Addressing virtually the inauguration of the Swaminarayan temple in Paris, PM Modi hoped that the grand temple in Paris will stand for centuries as a symbol of cooperation and opportunity between both the nations. “In recent years, relations between India and France have reached new heights. Together with my friend, President (Emmanuel) Macron, both nations are building a Special Global Strategic Partnership,” he said.

The prime minister said that from technology, AI, and defence to space and climate action, India and France are moving forward together with new momentum and energy.

AGENCIES

New Delhi, September 6

Russian Ambassador to India Denis Alipov reiterated India’s stance by saying that New Delhi purchases Russian oil for its own energy security, not to help Moscow fund the Ukraine war.

“India does not buy Russian oil for the sake of helping Russia. It is buying oil for itself and its own national development, keeping in mind the well-being and welfare of its own people,” Alipov said in an interview with DD News.

His statement landed amid intense scrutiny in Washington and other Western capitals over India’s purchases of Russian oil.

India sharply increased imports of discounted Russian crude after the Ukraine war began in 2022, making Moscow one of India’s biggest oil suppliers.

The United States is considering legislation, such as

AMID US TARIFF THREAT

India buys oil for itself, not to help Moscow, says Russian envoy Alipov



Russian Ambassafor to India Denis Alipov

KEY POINTS

- » India sharply increased imports of discounted Russian crude after the Ukraine war began in 2022, making Moscow one of India’s biggest oil suppliers
- » ‘The question from my point of view is how confident India is. But it has shown that it’s able to stand its ground and defend India’s national security and national interests’

the proposed Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act, that grants the president discretionary authority to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on imports from the five

largest buyers of Russian crude oil or natural gas.

The proposed legislation argues that such trade helps Russia’s economy by which in turn makes it eas-

ier for the nation to finance its military operations in Ukraine.

Along with targeting Russian President Vladimir Putin, the bill mandates severe direct sanctions on top military generals, state-owned banks and energy projects.

Alipov told ANI that those imposing such measures have chosen “pressure tactics instead of honest cooperation” over the particular matter.

“Unfortunately, those who impose sanctions and tariffs have taken the path of pressure tactics instead of honest cooperation. Who prevents those countries from offering a better deal to India in oil than us? But nobody is able to do that. Hence the pressure and punitive measures,” the Russian envoy said.

“The question from my point of view is how confident India is. But it has shown that it’s able to stand its ground and defend India’s national security

and national interests,” he added.

He said that Russia is willing to supply India with as much oil as it requires.

Meanwhile, External Affairs minister S Jaishankar, who was in Kyiv for an official visit on Friday, said curtailing India’s purchase of Russian oil will not stop the war in Ukraine, pushing back on the Western position that cutting Moscow’s economic lifeline would force it to abandon the conflict.

Addressing the media, the minister stressed that the conflict, which is in its fifth year, could only be resolved by dialogue, diplomacy, and negotiation.

“This conflict, which is today in its fifth year, will not be solved because somebody is buying or not buying oil or alumina or minerals or metals or fertiliser. This conflict will be solved by dialogue, diplomacy, and negotiation,” Jaishankar said after he met with Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha.

Saharanpur mosque demolition triggers political storm

Opposition leaders question Uttar Pradesh government’s action

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

Lucknow, September 6

The demolition of an old mosque located on the Saharanpur Collectorate premises has triggered a political confrontation in Uttar Pradesh, with Opposition leaders questioning the administration’s decision and alleging that the religious structure was razed despite legal options still being available to the mosque committee.

Former chief ministers Mayawati and Akhilesh Yadav, AIMIM president Asaduddin Owaisi, Congress MP Imran Masood, Nagina MP Chandrashekar Azad and Kairana MP Iqra Hasan have criticised the action, while local leaders have announced plans to challenge the demolition in court.

The administration had declared the mosque illegal before carrying out the demolition. Opposi-



THE ADMINISTRATION HAD DECLARED THE MOSQUE ILLEGAL BEFORE CARRYING OUT THE DEMOLITION

tion leaders, however, have disputed the circumstances and timing of the action, with several claiming that the mosque committee possessed old documents relating to the structure and that sufficient time had not been given to pursue legal remedies.

From page 1

Students hostel caves

the day. The All India Institute of Medical Sciences trauma centre said it received ten patients, of whom four were brought dead and a fifth died later from his injuries while undergoing treatment. Three patients remained admitted, one of whom had limb surgery, while another was discharged after observation. A 19-year-old was also taken to Safdarjung Hospital with minor injuries. Officials said the overall toll stood at five dead, with several more listed as critical.

Two teams from the National Disaster Response Force, comprising about 70 personnel along with a canine squad, were deployed to the site, with two more teams kept on standby. Oxygen cylinders were lowered into the debris for anyone still breathing underneath. Rescuers used collapsed structure search and rescue gear, including diamond chain saws, hydraulic jacks, inflatable bags, combi cutters, plasma cutters and life-detection equipment to locate survivors. According to the NDRF, it typically took about 15 minutes to free a person once located, though one operation to extract two casualties took half an hour. Delhi Police, Fire Services, the CATS ambulance service, the Delhi Disaster Management Authority, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi and Civil Defence teams also joined the operation, alongside at least eight fire tenders.

Before official rescuers arrived, students and residents dug into the wreckage themselves. “We formed a human chain because there was so much rubble,” said Abhishek Mishra, a first-year law student who was nearby when the building fell. He said the ground shook and a wall of dust rose from the site moments before people rushed in to help clear debris by hand.

A video reportedly recorded by a trapped student named Aditya, showing his bloodied face amid broken concrete, circulated among students afterward. Another student, Sunny Dheda, said he rushed to the site after a call from his friend Shantanu, who was sleeping in the PG when it collapsed and was later admitted to hospital in critical condition.

Locals blamed the collapse on repair work being carried out in the basement, along with days of rainwater pooling

there and weakening the foundation. Police said construction activity in the basement was underway at the time, though the Municipal Corporation said it could not confirm this until the debris was cleared. A senior civic official, Rakesh Kumar, said an adjoining building housing a girls’ PG had been found in poor condition and was sealed and evacuated as a precaution, with residents shifted to a nearby community hall and to Atma Ram Sanatan Dharm College.

Police booked the building’s owner, identified as Hari Ram, on charges including culpable homicide and negligence, and said several teams had been formed to trace those responsible. Students said the actual building had been rented out to Hostel Daze by a local shopkeeper named Anand Bansal. A company representative said students in its other properties nearby were safe and that one hostel gate had been locked from outside only to prevent panic. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visited the site and the AIIMS trauma centre and ordered a magisterial inquiry along with a police case against the owner. Union Home Minister Amit Shah cut short a visit to Goa to return to Delhi and spoke with the chief minister, the police commissioner and the NDRF chief. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu also expressed concern and said authorities were coordinating the rescue effort.

Residents in the area said many of the PGs, including the one that collapsed, were repainted before each academic session to appear well kept, even as structural checks were rarely carried out. “Buildings here are being constructed up to five-six floors,” said Priyanka, a resident of more than two decades, adding that she had never seen real upkeep of the structures around her.

India supports UN map

India’s official map. Any inaccurate or misleading depiction is unacceptable,” he said.

“Our position on India’s sovereignty and territorial integrity is clear, consistent and non-negotiable,” he noted.

Jaiswal said the purpose of the UN resolution is “to encourage the use of equal-area map projections that preserve the relative sizes of continental landmasses.”

“The resolution neither adopts nor authenticates any particular world map, nor does

it address political cartography, including international boundaries, disputed territories or place names,” he said.

The resolution, sponsored by Togo, received 164 votes in favour, with abstentions from Estonia, Georgia, Lithuania, Moldova, Serbia and Ukraine, and a lone vote against from the United States. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Spurious liquor claims

an official tour of Dubai.

Several patients in critical condition were shifted to the district hospital and Bundelkhand Medical College in Sagar, while some were airlifted to Bhopal for specialised treatment.

Deputy CM Devda also sought an immediate report from officials and directed them to ensure a prompt probe, adequate medical treatment and relief for those affected.

“Initial investigations indicate that spurious liquor supplied to local villages caused the casualties, pointing to a serious lapse by local Excise officials,” Excise Commissioner Deepak Saxena told reporters in the affected area.

The Commissioner said Deputy Excise Commissioner, Sagar Division, Neeraja Shrivastava, had been shifted to headquarters, while Assistant Excise Commissioner Kirti Dubey, ADEO Dilip Khandate and ESI Proshani Ureti had also been suspended.

Meanwhile, a preliminary police probe indicates a possible Uttar Pradesh link to the illicit liquor supply network, which is being verified by senior police officers, the Commissioner said.

The incident was reported from villages in Banda block, including Gogra-Khurd, Nauraj and Patan, where several people allegedly consumed liquor on Saturday night and later developed symptoms including vomiting, nausea and breathing difficulties. As their condition worsened, several were rushed to hospitals.

The incident has also brought an alleged cross-border illicit liquor network under the scanner. Preliminary findings suggest a racket in Uttar Pradesh’s Lalitpur district may have been manufacturing counterfeit liquor and supplying it cheaply to villages in border areas of Sagar.

The suspected supply chain surfaced after Lalitpur Police recently busted a gang allegedly involved in manufacturing and distributing illicit liquor. During questioning, the

accused reportedly told investigators that counterfeit liquor was being supplied to Banda and other areas of Sagar. The racket is suspected of using fake labels, bottle caps and QR codes to pass off counterfeit liquor as genuine. The consignments were allegedly transported by cars and motorcycles to villages in the affected area and its adjoining areas.

Investigators are verifying whether the liquor consumed by the victims came from the Lalitpur network and tracing its route to Sagar, along with those allegedly involved in its local distribution.

Banda police station SHO Rajendra Singh Kushwaha and Gugra Chauki in-charge Pooran Lal Ladia have also been suspended following the CM’s directions.

The administration has sealed liquor outlets in the affected area and intensified inspections of licensed and suspected illegal liquor points. Police and Excise teams are probing the source and distribution network.

Medical teams are conducting door-to-door screening in the affected villages. Officials have advised anyone developing symptoms after consuming liquor to seek immediate medical attention.

Death toll reaches 1,344

collecting DNA samples from relatives of missing people, while more than 1,000 unidentified bodies have been buried after DNA samples were preserved for future identification.

Hospitals have struggled with the number of bodies as families gather at medical facilities carrying photographs of missing relatives and checking images of recovered victims.

Information and Communication Minister Bikram Timilsina said the government would prevent shortages and mismanagement of relief supplies. “Nepal demands climate justice at this moment and the international community should be serious about this,” he said.

Supply disruptions have also affected Kathmandu Valley after erosion by the Trishuli River damaged the Prithvi Highway at Krishnabhir in Dhading on August 30. Nepal Oil Corporation said 87,877 LPG cylinders supplied by 18 companies reached the Valley through alternative routes between September 3 and 6. Spokesperson Manoj Thakur said petroleum and LPG supplies were continuing despite the highway

disruption. Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal and South Korean Foreign Minister Cho Hyun discussed rescue operations on Sunday, including efforts to find missing South Korean nationals. Khanal thanked Seoul for sending response and disaster relief teams. Cho said South Korea was willing to support Nepal’s reconstruction.

Kathmandu has also asked countries to restrict travel advisories to flood-hit areas, saying the rest of Nepal remains open to tourists. The request followed a US advisory on September 4 placing Nepal under Level 2. Tourism accounted for 6.4 per cent of Nepal’s GDP and 15.2 per cent of employment in 2024, according to World Bank data.

Meanwhile, fresh flooding in Gorkha’s Chumnubri Rural Municipality-4 on Sunday swept away four houses and a suspension bridge and damaged two small hydropower projects. Residents escaped before the Namrung Khola surge arrived, and no casualties were reported. Authorities urged communities along the Budhigandaki River, into which the Namrung Khola flows, to remain alert.

Centre appoints

High Court, Justice Alpesh Yeshwant Kogje of the Gujarat High Court as Chief Justice of the Madhya Pradesh High Court, and Justice Pushpendra Singh Bhati of the Rajasthan High Court as Chief Justice of the Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh High Court.

The appointments follow a controversy in Rajasthan, where serious allegations were made by Supreme Court judge Justice Sandeep Mehta against acting Chief Justice Sanjeev Prakash Sharma.

Separately, sources familiar with the judicial appointment process said 25 recommendations made by the Supreme Court Collegium are still pending with the government. The names are spread mainly across the Delhi, Calcutta, Madras, Punjab and Haryana, and Gujarat high courts, among others.

Kirpal’s case is the oldest pending recommendation. The Delhi High Court Collegium first recommended him in October 2017. The Supreme Court Collegium deferred consideration of his name three times before the collegium headed by then Chief Justice of India N V Ramana recommended his appointment in November 2021. The government returned the file for reconsideration in November

2022. After the Collegium reiterated its recommendation, the file has remained pending.

The appointment process begins with high court collegiums recommending advocates and judicial officers. The Union Law Ministry’s Department of Justice gathers inputs, including Intelligence Bureau reports, before sending the files to the Supreme Court Collegium, which either recommends the candidates or sends the files back.

The 25 pending recommendations are fewer than in recent periods, sources said. However, the high courts continue to face a substantial vacancy burden. Against the sanctioned strength of 1,122 judges, only 818 are currently working, leaving 27 per cent of posts vacant.

Centre sells

The government is holding 1.21 lakh tonnes of buffer onion for 2026 through NCCF and Nafed. The agencies are moving stocks from producing states to major consumption centres by trucks and a dedicated rail service called “Kanda Express”. The onions are being sold at Rs 35 per kg in selected price-sensitive cities. “Approximately 4,000 tonnes of buffer onion have been sold so far in 17 cities,” Khare said. Bulk consignments have reached Delhi and Chennai by rail, while a third Kanda Express rake is being loaded for Guwahati.

NCCF Managing Director Anice Joseph Chandra said NCCF alone has sold 1,500 tonnes. The federation is retailing through stores, mobile vans and cooperative societies across Delhi-NCR, Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh, Kerala, Rajasthan, Punjab, Odisha and other states. Chandra said the intervention has reduced prices by Rs 2-3 per kg. However, the all-India average retail price rose to Rs 50.79 per kg on September 5 from Rs 48.5 on August 28. Untimely rains damaged some rabi onions. Officials expect the new kharif crop from mid-October to improve supplies and ease prices.AGENCIES

Minor CJP student

as “goons” had surrounded the family’s residence and pelted it with stones and bricks. “What if something happens to my parents? Who will be held responsible for that?” she asked in one of the videos. She also said she had “genuine concerns” about her safety.

The allegations came shortly

after right-wing content creator Swatantra Bhardwaj, 21, was arrested in connection with the alleged assault on her father, Sanjay Azad, during protests at Jantar Mantar in June. A Delhi court on Saturday sent Bhardwaj to one-day police custody.

The case returned to public attention after Bhardwaj reportedly said during a podcast that he had “cracked the skull” of Azad. He also claimed that police had let him go because of his alleged links with BJP leader Kapil Mishra and Union minister Chirag Paswan.

NSUI National President Vinod Jakhar visited the family’s residence on Saturday after the minor’s videos appeared online. He questioned the alleged delay in police action against Bhardwaj.

“Swatantra Bhardwaj himself said that he had attacked her father,” Jakhar said, alleging that police became active only after Congress leader Rahul Gandhi raised the issue.

Separately, Supreme Court lawyer Amita Sachdeva has filed a complaint at a Delhi Cyber Police Station against the father and daughter, alleging that four social media posts published between September 2023 and August 2026 contained derogatory references to Hindu deities, including Bhagwan Shiv, Bhagwan Shri Krishna, Maa Saraswati and Maa Durga.

Sachdeva has sought an FIR under Sections 299 and 196 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and relevant provisions of the Information Technology Act. She has also sought preservation of posts, media, platform records, IP logs, device details and other electronic evidence.

The minor has disputed the authenticity of at least some posts cited or circulated in connection with the complaint, calling them “fake and AI created”. She shared screenshots on X while rejecting their authenticity. Establishing whether the material was genuine would require verification through police investigation and digital evidence.

Jan Dhan

The Centre said it does not centrally maintain gender-wise data on account balances, zero-balance or inoperative accounts. It also does not maintain central figures for accounts holding less than Rs 100, accounts closed during the past five years, or accounts blocked or frozen over suspected transactions or cyber fraud.

The state-wise figures supplied in the RTI response cover 36 states and Union territories.



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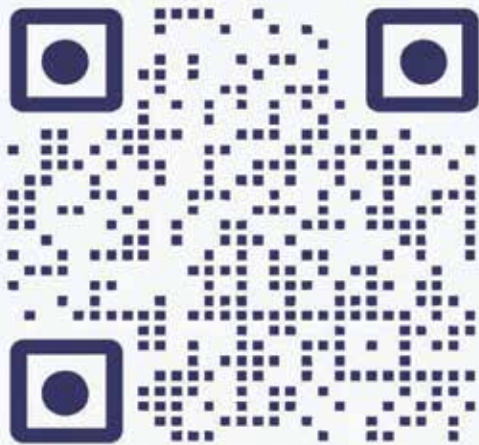
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Briefs

Rajnath to travel to Sri Lanka

NEW DELHI: Defence minister Rajnath Singh will undertake a three-day trip to Sri Lanka beginning Tuesday to explore ways to further shore up bilateral defence and military ties.

Singh will be accompanied by a high-level delegation comprising senior officials from the defence and external affairs ministries, according to an official statement.

Meghalaya: Former MLA joins BJP

SHILLONG: Former Meghalaya MLA Jemino Mawthoh on Sunday announced that he and his supporters will join the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on September 12.

Mawthoh, who resigned from the UDP in May after serving as its vice president and general secretary for several years, said he took the decision following a meeting with his supporters on Saturday.

OBC activists launch counter-stir

JALNA: Activists of the Other Backward Classes (OBC) community on Sunday launched an indefinite hunger strike in Maharashtra's Jalna district, meters away from Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange's protest site.

The development came on the ninth day of Jarange's indefinite fast at Antarwali Sarti village, where his health reportedly deteriorated after he refused medical aid, water, and intravenous fluids to demand OBC status for the Maratha community.

Jiten Manjhi admitted to AIIMS

NEW DELHI: Union minister Jiten Ram Manjhi was admitted to AIIMS here on Sunday evening after he complained of breathing difficulties and fever, sources said.

Manjhi, the minister for micro, small and medium enterprises, was brought to the emergency department at around 5 pm and shifted to the ICU at around 9 pm, they said.

Tawde is 'pagal': Akhilesh

AURAIYA: Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday called Bharatiya Janata Party's Uttar Pradesh in-charge Vinod Tawde 'pagal' (mad) in response to his sarcastic dig at the opposition party's 'PDA' slogan, which he referred to as 'paraya dhan apna'.

Reacting to Tawde's "dhan" remark, Yadav said that the ruling BJP knows better how to grab someone else's "dhan" and make it its own.

1.89 LAKH DELETED, 56,871 ADDED

Post-SIR Manipur voter list released with 19.6L electors

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Imphal, September 6

The Election Commission on Sunday released Manipur's final electoral roll following the Special Intensive Revision, with 19.60 lakh voters figured on the list, deleting 1.89 lakh and adding 56,871 during the exercise.

State Chief Electoral Officer Arun Kumar Sinha said women outnumbered men in the post-SIR voter roll.

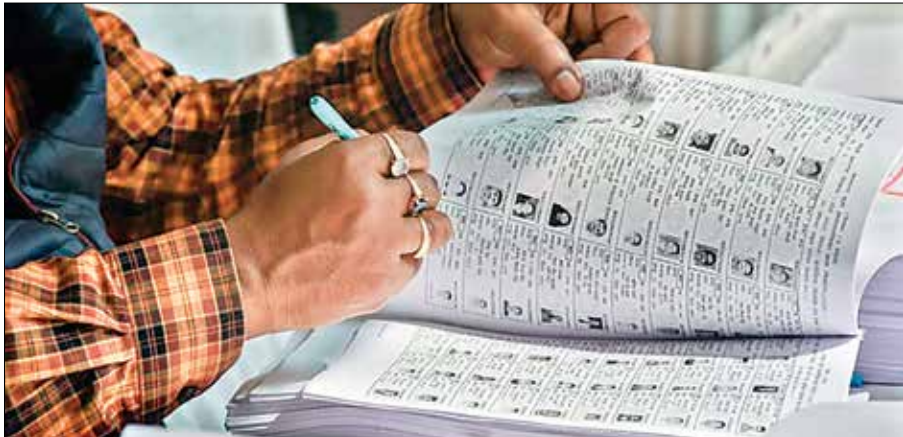
"After the SIR exercise, the state now has over 19.60 lakh electors across 60 Assembly constituencies. Of the total voters, 9,53,350 are men and 10.06 women. There are 308 third-gender electors," he said.

Sinha said the revision exercise began with 20.93 lakh electors on the voter list as of May 18 this year.

The number of voters in the final roll is 6.33 per cent less than the number of electors before the beginning of the revision exercise.

The draft electoral roll, published on July 5, had 19.34 lakh electors.

"During the claims and objections period from July 5 to August 4, the authorities received 96,985 claims and objections, all of which were processed for final publication. The final list includes 56,871 additions, while 30,650 electors were deleted from the



CLOSER LOOK

- » State Chief Electoral Officer Arun Kumar Sinha said women outnumbered men in the post-SIR voter roll
- » The number of voters in the final roll is 6.33 per cent less than the number of electors before the beginning of the revision exercise

draft roll," he said.

The gender ratio stands at 1,056, while the electoral participation ratio is recorded at 51.99, he said.

"Enumeration forms were generated and distributed to all electors, of which 19,34,399 forms were returned," he said, adding that the remaining 1,58,677 electors were excluded.

Based on probable reasons, including being absent, shifted, deceased, duplicate entries and other reasons, the excluded electors were categorised, he said.

"As many as 34,740 were classified as absent electors, 72,473 as shifted electors, 43,000 as deceased electors, 7,394 as duplicate entries and 1,070 cases were given under other reasons," he added.

Manipur was among 19 states and Union Territories where the voter roll revision was being carried out in the third phase of the special intensive revision.

In 2025, the first phase of the exercise was conducted in Bihar. It was extended to 12 states and Union Territories, includ-

ing West Bengal, Uttar Pradesh and Tamil Nadu, in the second phase in late 2025 and the first half of 2026.

Meanwhile, last week, the Centre deferred the census operations in Manipur amid demands from Meitei and Naga organisations for the implementation of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) before the census and delimitation exercises.

Following the Centre's decision, the Ministry of Home Affairs on Saturday issued a gazette notification formally deferring the census exercise in the state.

Last Wednesday, the Manipur Assembly reaffirmed its previous resolutions urging the central government to "update" the NRC before conducting the census "in the interest of the state in particular and the nation in general."

Punjab: Sachin Pilot appointed general secretary in-charge

Pilot in driver's seat after replacing Bhupesh Baghel

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 6

Congress leader Sachin Pilot has seen several ups and downs in his over two-decades-long career but the party's youth poster boy is fast-emerging as its go-to trump card to swing electoral fortunes in tough states.

That his stature in the Congress is becoming formidable can be gauged from the fact that he has been entrusted with putting the house in order in Punjab where the party is facing infighting right at the cusp of Assembly polls with several factions battling it out for an upper hand.

The Congress on Saturday carried out a major organisational reshuffle and appointed Pilot as general secretary in-charge of poll-bound Punjab, replacing Bhupesh Baghel.



Sachin Pilot

Incidentally, Pilot till now was in-charge of Chhattisgarh where Baghel is a key leader and a former chief minister. Baghel will now look after Assam, replacing Jitendra Singh.

Punjab goes to polls early next year and Pilot's immediate challenge will be to address factionalism within the state unit ahead of crucial elections.

At a time when other political parties have stepped up preparations for the Punjab elections, the Congress has largely

been seen firefighting the internal feud and bickering despite repeated assertions by the leadership that the efforts were underway to strengthen the organisational unity ahead of the polls.

The infighting was triggered after the Congress leadership on July 1 announced its decision to retain Amrinder Singh Raja Warring as the state unit chief and appoint former chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi as the chairperson of its campaign committee.

A section of leaders led by Channi opposed the move to retain Warring as the Punjab Congress president and sought his removal from the position. The supporters of Channi have been seeking that he be announced as the chief ministerial face for the 2027 Assembly polls.

Sikkim SIR: Names of 11% voters deleted

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Gangtok, September 6

A total of 52,551 electors were deleted from Sikkim's electoral roll during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), reducing the number of voters by around 11.16 per cent, a statement said on Sunday.

The final roll has 4,18,467 eligible voters, compared with 4,71,018 in the pre-SIR voters' list, the Chief Electoral Officer's (CEO) office said in a statement.

The draft electoral

roll released in July had 4,33,294 electors, of whom 3,61,159 or 83.35 per cent were successfully mapped with their own or parents' electoral details from the previous qualifying roll or the last SIR.

The remaining 72,135 electors (16.65 per cent) could not be mapped, it said. Among the mapped electors, 52,384 were identified by the Election Commission's IT system as having "Logical Discrepancies".

A total of 1,24,519 electors, comprising those in

the unmapped and Logical Discrepancy categories, were issued notices to appear for hearings and establish their eligibility, the statement said.

Following hearings and verification, 16,485 electors were found ineligible, the CEO's office said.

Another 324 electors were deleted through Form 7 on grounds including death or shifting from the address.

Thus, a total of 16,809 electors were deleted during the claims and objections process.

New adjective every year to hide own failures: Cong attacks govt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 6

The Congress on Sunday said Prime Minister Narendra Modi's use of labels such as "naraaz phoop" was part of his modus operandi of giving the Opposition a new adjective every year to keep his own "failures" hidden.

The Opposition party also accused him of misusing the platform of Delhi University's Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC), where he addressed the centenary celebrations on Saturday, by turning it into "yet another political campaign".

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said, "Narendra Modi ji, yesterday, you visited SRCC at Delhi University. It was an opportunity for dialogue on the country's youth, education, and their future. But alas, instead of facing the youth's questions, the speech turned into yet another political



Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge

campaign."

"Modi ji's Modus Operandi is to suppress questions in a democracy and give the Opposition a new adjective every year so that his own failures remain hidden! Naraaz phoop, Dimagi Naxal, Urban Naxal, Khan Market Gang, Andolan-jeevi, Parjeevi," Kharge said in a post in Hindi on X.

Adjectives keep changing, but the Modi government's "anti-people policies" do not change, Kharge said.

"Modi ji, outreach is only needed when you

become out of reach. The prime minister showed his 'report card'. The country's youth is also standing up with its report card, and it includes unemployment, government recruitments stuck for years, students troubled by paper leaks, increasingly expensive education, dwindling scholarship opportunities, and growing pressure on the autonomy of universities," Kharge said.

Listen to "Chhatron Ki Goonj" as solutions won't come from beating around the bush, Congress president said.

ISRO says it will not be privatised nor its importance will be diminished

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 6

The Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) on Sunday issued a clarification, saying that neither it would be privatised nor would its importance be diminished.

In a post on X, the space agency asserted that participation of the private sector enables ISRO to focus strongly on the next generation of India's space programme, while the industry scales mature technologies and capabilities.

The development came after nine employee associations at ISRO wrote to the space agency's Chairperson V Narayanan on September 4, seeking official clarification on the proposed transfer of its manufacturing and operational functions to private entities.

They were referring to the remarks made by Pawan Goenka, chairperson of the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPaCE), on August 21.

ISRO said in the post that its "role will progressively strengthen in areas where its scientific expertise matters most: frontier R&D, advanced technologies, human spaceflight, next-generation launch systems, deep-space and planetary missions and strategic national capabilities."

The space agency added that it would continue developing cutting-edge technologies, including advanced payloads for communication, navigation and Earth observation, sensors, propulsion systems and other critical technologies.

BJP MP DESCRIBES RSS AS A SOURCE OF NATIONAL PRIDE

RSS-run schools in Himachal if BJP returns: Kangana

ASHWANI SHARMA

Shimla September 6

Bharatiya Janata Party MP Kangana Ranaut on Sunday promised RSS-backed schools in Himachal if BJP regains Power in Himachal Pradesh.

Currently in Himachal Pradesh, where he also chaired a meeting of the District Development Coordination and Monitoring Committee (DISHA) at Mandi, questioning the government officials on non-utilisation of the MPLAD funds, the BJP MP commended the decision of West Bengal chief minister Suwendu Adhikari to estab-



Kangana Ranaut

lish 1,000 Vidya Bharati institutions across the state.

She described RSS as a source of national pride, noting that the organisation has established numerous schools and has served the nation during times of cri-

sis. In quick response to the WB government proposal, Ranaut advocated for the idea of establishing Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS)-run schools in Himachal Pradesh when the BJP returns to power in the

state.

"It is a good move and should be replicated in the state," she said.

Referring to Eklavya Model Schools and NEET preparation programmes for the students, Ranaut

KEY POINTS

- » Referring to Eklavya Model Schools and NEET preparation programmes for the students, Ranaut asserted that these schools provide better opportunities for students in rural and remote regions
- » Ranaut, in a DISHA meeting was heard taking officials to task over what she described as delays in using public money

asserted that these schools provide better opportunities for students in rural and remote regions.

Vidya Bharati, the education wing of the RSS, is preparing for a major expansion of its school network in West Bengal. The organisation also plans to establish a presence in all 345 blocks of West Bengal over the next few years.

Meanwhile, earlier on Saturday, Ranaut, in a DISHA meeting (a video of which has gone viral), was heard taking officials to task over what she described as delays in using public money.

"What is this behaviour?"

EDITORIAL

India's BRICS Economic Imperatives

The BRICS Summit in New Delhi gives India an opportunity to move the grouping beyond declarations of solidarity towards tangible economic outcomes. As BRICS has expanded, its economic weight gives it increasing influence over global commerce. But greater collective size does not automatically advance Indian interests. New Delhi's first imperative must be trade that is broader and more balanced. India cannot measure successful BRICS engagement merely by rising commerce while large trade deficits persist with important partners. It should seek better market access for pharmaceuticals, engineering goods, agricultural products and services, while helping Indian MSMEs enter supply chains across member economies. Cooperation on standards, customs procedures, logistics and digital documentation could reduce barriers that hurt smaller exporters. India should use BRICS to diversify supply chains rather than replace dependence on one set of countries with dependence on another. Reliable access to energy, fertilisers, critical minerals and industrial inputs will become increasingly important as geopolitical disruptions reshape global commerce.

Finance is the second major imperative. BRICS has discussed reducing the costs and vulnerabilities of cross-border transactions, and India should advance this agenda without turning it into a symbolic confrontation with the dollar. National-currency settlement and interoperable payment systems could make transactions faster and cheaper where commercially viable. India's experience in digital infrastructure gives it an opportunity to shape such cooperation, provided cybersecurity, transparency, regulatory safeguards and monetary sovereignty remain central. Development finance deserves equal attention. India needs investment in transport, urban infrastructure, renewable energy, electricity grids, manufacturing and climate resilience. The New Development Bank can become more relevant by expanding local-currency financing and supporting projects struggling to obtain affordable long-term capital. India should press for mechanisms improving access to credit for MSMEs. Unless smaller businesses can obtain finance, technology and overseas customers, BRICS cooperation will remain concentrated among governments and large corporations. The summit should help mobilise capital for investment and enable Indian enterprises to expand beyond domestic markets.

The larger challenge is ensuring that geopolitics does not overwhelm economics. BRICS contains countries with different strategic alignments and commercial priorities, making consensus harder as the grouping grows. India has little interest in allowing it to become an anti-Western coalition or an arena for another great-power rivalry. Its value lies instead in giving developing economies greater bargaining power while preserving India's strategic autonomy and relationships across blocs. New Delhi should concentrate on achievable objectives: trade links, diversified supply chains, technology partnerships, affordable development finance, energy security and representation for emerging economies in global institutions. India should push cooperation in artificial intelligence, clean technologies and advanced manufacturing, areas that will determine competitiveness and productivity. The summit's success will not be determined by ambitious declarations about a new world order. It will be measured by whether Indian exporters find markets, businesses obtain cheaper finance, infrastructure attracts investment and supply chains become safer. Turning BRICS' political weight into economic opportunity is the real imperative before India.

LETTER



letter2editor.mp@gmail.com.

Preventing Regional War

The Reports that Iran may be seeking coordinated action by its regional allies against Israel are deeply alarming. A simultaneous conflict involving multiple armed groups could trigger devastating consequences far beyond Israel and Iran. Regional powers and the international community must prioritise diplomacy before another confrontation spirals into a wider war.

ARUN MEHTA, NEW DELHI

You can also send your comments to The Editor, Millennium Post, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002

TALKING SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER IS A JOURNALIST & COMMUNICATIONS SPECIALIST

"Eat food. Not too much. Mostly plants." — Michael Pollan

There is something wonderfully optimistic about a food packet. Read the wrapper and you are promised energy, goodness, fibre, vitamins, happiness and even a life-changing experience, sometimes involving chocolate. But what of the inconvenient truth, which is printed somewhere behind all the optimism, in tiny letters and tinier numbers?

For years, consumers have been expected to navigate this nutritional minefield on their own. Calories, carbohydrates, fats, sodium, serving sizes, percentages and ingredients compete for attention, while the front of the packet cheerfully announces that the contents are 'natural', 'light', 'zero sugar', 'multigrain' or otherwise virtuous.

Now, finally, there may be some adult supervision.

The Red Hexagon

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has proposed prominent red, hexagonal warning labels on packaged foods high in sugar, salt or fat (HFSS).

WARNING SIGNS



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS A RETIRED IPS OFFICER, ADVISER NATSTRAT

In a dramatic court verdict on July 31, the Colombo Permanent High Court Trial-at-Bar sentenced former Inspector General of Police Pujith Jayasundara and former Secretary to the Ministry of Defence Hemasiri Fernando to death over their failure to act on intelligence warnings of the impending Easter Sunday attacks which shook Sri Lanka on April 21, 2019. The judgment was, however, divided. Presiding Judge Priyantha Liyanage and Judge Thilakarathna Bandara convicted the two former officials, while Judge Viraj Weerasuriya held that the prosecution had failed to prove the charges beyond reasonable doubt. Jayasundara and Fernando are expected to appeal (Sri Lanka has maintained a moratorium on the death penalty since 1976). Therefore, the importance of the July 31 judgment does not neces-

The Warning Label Needs a Warning

India is finally moving towards clear front-of-pack warnings on packaged food. But unless the fine print is fixed, the warning itself may come with a loophole



Front-of-pack labels must make unhealthy ingredients easy to understand

The move follows months of judicial pressure, culminating in the Supreme Court directive that the Government move on front-of-pack warnings, rather than continue debating the matter. It is a welcome move. But welcome is not the same as unquestionable.

To FSSAI's credit, under CEO Rajit Punhani's stewardship, the regulator has shown a welcome willingness to bring greater transparency to a food market that has long been far too comfortable with confusing consumers. The whole point of a front-of-pack warning is to simplify information. A consumer should be able to look at a packet and understand, instantly, whether it contains unusually high levels of something he or she might reasonably want to limit. That is what the red hexagon promises.

The Fine Print

The problem, as always, lies in the small print. Under the proposal's first phase, a warning would be triggered when a product is high in two or more of the three nutrients of concern. That means a product

THE FRONT OF A FOOD PACKET SHOULD INFORM US IN SECONDS, NOT DEMAND A DEGREE IN NUTRITION

exceptionally high in sugar could escape a warning if it happens to be below the threshold for salt and fat. The same logic could allow a very salty product to pass without the red flag.

This is an odd way to construct a warning system. A danger does not become less dangerous because another danger is absent. The second phase is meant to address this by extending the warning to products high in any one of the specified nutrients. But there is no binding timeline for when that phase will begin.

A temporary arrangement is understandable. An indefinite one

is not. And there is a larger principle at stake—the purpose of front-of-pack labelling is not to produce more information. India already has plenty of that. Its purpose is to make important information impossible to miss.

FSSAI Steps Up

FSSAI's Punhani, in a recent interview, was equally measured on palm oil, an ingredient that has become something of a nutritional villain. His point was that palm oil—or any other oil for that matter—when it meets prescribed standards, is not inherently unsafe; what matters is how much is consumed and the nutritional character of the food in which it is used.

In Parliament during the Monsoon Session, Union Minister Prataprao Jadhav made essentially the same point, saying palm oil is a standardised edible fat permitted under FSSAI regulations and subject to scientific and Codex-based standards. Manufacturers, he added, must identify the specific edible oil used, rather than hide behind the

generic term 'edible vegetable oil'. That is the balance a good labelling regime should seek. Consumers should not be frightened into believing that the mere presence of plant-based oils makes a pack of chips poisonous. Nor should a product escape scrutiny because its packaging is clever enough to make its less desirable nutritional characteristics inconspicuous. The ingredient is not the whole story. The product is.

The Consumer Test

This is where the proposed red hexagon matters. A consumer buying a packet of biscuits should not need to conduct a forensic examination before discovering that it contains excessive sugar. A parent buying a drink for a child should not have to decipher a table of numbers while standing in a supermarket aisle. A warning label is supposed to do the heavy lifting.

Sure, there is a legitimate argument for getting the thresholds right. Industry, meanwhile, will worry about reformulation costs, traditional foods being unfairly caught and the possibility that too many warnings could make the system meaningless. Those concerns deserve a hearing. Regulation works best when it is scientifically defensible, predictable and practical.

But there is another stakeholder whose voice must not disappear in the technical debate: the consumer. For years, the packaged-food industry has been remarkably adept at telling consumers what is inside a packet without necessarily telling them what that means.

A red hexagon can change that. But only if it is allowed to do its job. If a product is high in sugar, it should say so. If it is high in salt, it should say so. If it is high in fat, it should say so. A warning should warn. It should not make the consumer wait for a second danger before acknowledging the first. India has taken a significant step. It should now have the confidence to make that warning meaningful.

Views expressed are personal

Deadly Cost of Inaction

Sri Lanka's death sentence verdict puts the onus on official accountability for intelligence failures



Ignored warnings now carry consequences for security establishment

SPECIFIC INTELLIGENCE INPUTS DEMAND ACTION WHEN LIVES AND NATIONAL SECURITY ARE AT STAKE

other words, there was a complete absence of coordination.

Jayasundara told the Court that he had been treated unjustly and had performed his duties to the fullest extent possible. He also said that more senior or directly responsible officials had been allowed to escape accountability. Fernando argued that he had been the Secretary to the Ministry of Defence, not the Minister of Defence.

Questions Of Authority

These arguments raise valid questions about the distribution

of authority within the security establishment during the Yahapalanaya Government. By late 2018, the Government was dysfunctional due to the political conflict between President Sirisena and then Prime Minister Ranil Wickremesinghe. Relations between the President and senior members of the Government had deteriorated to such an extent that Wickremesinghe was not invited to NSC briefings. The statements made by Fernando have also raised questions about the conduct of former State Intelligence Service (SIS) Director Nilantha Jayawardena, who had received the original intelligence.

On November 5, 2024, a five-member Supreme Court bench comprising Justices Preethi Padman Surasena, Yasantha Kodagoda, Kumudini Wickremesinghe, Mahinda Samayawardhena and Arjuna Obeyesekere held that, given the gravity and complexity of the case, the High Court should have called for the defence. It ordered the trial

to continue. Had the Supreme Court allowed the original acquittals to stand, the case would have ended without the defence being heard. The judge who headed that Supreme Court bench was Preethi Padman Surasena, who is now the Chief Justice, having assumed office in July 2025.

Accountability Matters

The 2019 Easter bombings were a series of coordinated suicide attacks in Sri Lanka carried out by local Islamist extremists, targeting three Christian churches and three luxury hotels on April 21, 2019, killing 279 people, including 45 foreign nationals, and injuring over 500. The perpetrators were suicide bombers linked to the local group National Thowheeth Jama'ath (NTJ), pledging allegiance to the Islamic State, and led locally by Zahran Hashim. Advance warnings provided by foreign intelligence, including India, weeks prior were ignored or not acted upon by top security leadership, which speaks poorly of the intelligence and security establishments.

Now that this judgment is pronounced, it is very likely to trigger debates on the accountability of the intelligence community failing to act upon specific preventable inputs. It would also be interesting to know if such a landmark judgment will send a strong message as a deterrent to the concerned agencies the world over, and future terror misadventures of similar occurrences could possibly be prevented. Whatever the outcome, this milestone verdict merits an in-depth analysis by those in the judicial and security fraternity.

Views expressed are personal

GANGA CROSSES HIGHEST FLOOD LEVEL IN PATNA

Bihar: Over 22L hit by floods

MPOST BUREAU
Patna, September 6

More than 22 lakh people in 12 districts of Bihar have been affected by a deluge as rivers overflowed following heavy rain in the state and neighbouring Jharkhand, with authorities sounding an alert as the water level in the Ganga crossed the highest flood level in Patna on Sunday.

In a notification, the East Central Railway cancelled and diverted some trains because of the alarmingly high water level at a bridge that connects Punpun and Parsa Bazar stations on the Patna-Gaya section. A total of 190 community kitchens were being operated in various districts for flood-affected people, while 1,429 boats have been pressed into service to take marooned people to safety, officials said. Besides, 27 teams of the State Disaster Response Force and 10 from the National Disaster Response Force have been deployed in various districts.

In Patna's Gandhi Ghat, the Ganga was flowing at 50.57 metres at 6 am on Sunday, which is 0.05 metres above its previous highest flood level (HFL) of 50.52 metres, recorded on August 21. In Pandarak, the river was flowing at 43.92 metres at 6 am, which is 0.19 metres above its previous HFL of 43.73 metres on August 16.

Several rivers such as the Gandak was flowing above the danger mark at Dumariaghat and Hajipur, the Kosi at Baltara



People wade through a flooded road following a rise in the water level of the Punpun river, in Patna, on Sunday

PTI

INSIGHT

- » A total of 190 community kitchens were being operated in various districts for flood-affected people
- » 1,429 boats have been pressed into service to take marooned people to safety

and Kursela, the Budhi Gandak at Khagaria, the Ganga at Hathidah, Bhagalpur, Kahalgaon, Buxar and Munger, the Punpun at Sripalpur, the Bagmati at Benibad and the Ghaghra at Darauli, officials said.

This was caused by heavy rainfall in the state and neighbouring Jharkhand. In September, the state received 69.1 mm of rainfall so far, which is 55 per cent above normal.

Officials said that Hathidah and other gauge sta-

tions in the state capital were likely to be impacted over the next one to three days, as the Ganga's water level topped the HFL at Gandhi Ghat in Patna following heavy rain.

Due to the rise in water levels of various rivers, around 22.42 lakh people in Patna, Bhojpur, Saran, Vaishali, Bhagalpur, Begusarai, Buxar, Samastipur, Munger, Katihar, Lakhisarai and Arwal have been affected by floods, they said. According to an advisory by the Water Resources Department (WRD), the water level of the Ganga at Hathidah may also cross its previous HFL, prompting heightened vigilance in Begusarai, Lakhisarai, Munger, Bhagalpur and Katihar districts.

Officials have been directed to remain alert and continuously monitor water levels, embankments, vulnerable locations and low-

lying areas, while taking precautionary measures as required. People in affected areas have been advised to avoid going near the river and remain cautious, the advisory stated.

The local administration has also been asked to monitor boat operations, prevent overloading and keep residents informed about the situation.

The weather office here has forecast light to moderate rainfall at several places across the state during the next two days, with the possibility of heavy rain at some locations.

The opposition parties in Bihar sought a national disaster status for the floods in the state.

Claiming that 76 per cent of the state has been affected by floods, RJD national working president Tejashwi Yadav said 19 districts were reeling under the deluge, with more than 20 lakh people affected.

Amit Shah unveils three-year roadmap to step up India's fight against narcotics

Narcotics not only destroy future generations but also finance terrorism

NARESH BISWANI
Panaji, September 6

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday unveiled a three-year, mission-mode roadmap for 2026-29 to intensify India's fight against drugs and narcotics, saying the government has moved from an ad-hoc approach to a coordinated and multi-layered strategy.

Addressing the media in Panaji, Shah said narcotics not only destroy future generations but also finance terrorism. He outlined a four-pillar strategy covering intelligence and enforcement, control of precursor and synthetic drugs, demand reduction and harm reduction, and capacity building and institutional coordination.

Shah said drug seizures had increased signifi-



cantly under the Modi government. Between 2004 and 2014, agencies seized around 26 lakh kg of narcotics valued at Rs 40,000 crore, compared with 1.19 crore kg worth Rs 1.89 lakh crore between 2014 and 2026. The quantity of drugs destroyed also rose from 3.36 lakh kg during 2004-14 to 48.68 lakh kg between 2014 and 2026, he said.

The minister said a four-tier National Coordination Committee for

Drug Law Enforcement (NCORD) mechanism was established in 2019, while dedicated Anti-Narcotics Task Forces have been proposed in every state and Union Territory.

The government has also established the NIDAAN database of narcotics offenders and is using technology to target drug trafficking through the darknet, encrypted mobile phones, cryptocurrency networks and synthetic drugs, Shah said.

Under the new roadmap, dossiers will be prepared on major drug kingpins, while cases involving commercial quantities of narcotics will undergo financial investigations to trace the flow of illicit money.

The BSF, CISF, Coast Guard, Customs and Direc-

torate of Revenue Intelligence will undertake risk-based profiling and strengthen surveillance and security at borders, ports and airports. Cargo security and intelligence capabilities will also be enhanced, he said.

Shah said the number of de-addiction centres would be increased three-fold to 1,751, with nearly 10,000 volunteers being involved in the campaign. Fully equipped Anti-Narcotics Task Forces are expected to be established in all states by March 2027.

The government has set a long-term target of creating a drug-free generation by 2047. Shah said 2026-27 would be treated as a mission-mode year, with specific targets and timelines and quarterly reviews to monitor progress.

UP: 6 killed in house-collapse mishaps

MPOST BUREAU
Lucknow, September 6

Four members of a family, including a man and his three minor daughters, were killed and another daughter seriously injured after their kutchra house collapsed amid rain in Kanpur district on Sunday, police said.

The incident occurred around 11 am in Hirni village, where five members of the family were trapped under the debris. Police, fire brigade personnel and local residents rescued them and took them to the

Community Health Centre (CHC) in Patara, where four were declared dead.

The deceased were identified as Mukesh Kumar and his daughters Maya (17), Neetu (seven) and Pallavi (five). His daughter Kajal, who was seriously injured, is undergoing treatment at Lala Lajpat Rai Hospital in Kanpur.

Kumar's cousin Tej Bahadur Singh alleged that police initially failed to respond to repeated calls from the family after the collapse, forcing villagers to undertake rescue

efforts themselves. The family also alleged delays in treatment at the CHC and demanded an impartial inquiry.

In Budaun, farmer Vinod (35) died and his wife was seriously injured after a wall of their kutchra house collapsed during heavy rain in Gurgaon village late Saturday night. In another rain-related incident in Ballia, six-year-old Kirti Rajbhar died after a mud wall collapsed on her in Naferpur village.

The bodies in all three cases were sent for post-mortem.

Pb govt objects to appointment of Justice Mishra as HC Chief Justice

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, September 6

The Punjab Cabinet on Sunday evening passed a resolution against the Centre notifying the appointment of Ashwani Kumar Mishra as the Chief Justice of Punjab and Haryana High Court, claiming it was done without awaiting the state government's views bypassing Constitutional norms and set procedures.

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann also wrote separate letters to President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, urging the Centre not to move forward with the administration of oath to Justice Mishra, which is scheduled for Monday, "till the state government's concerns are adequately addressed".

The Centre notified Justice Mishra's appointment on Saturday, about a month after the Supreme Court Collegium had recommended his elevation. He has been functioning as

IT CLAIMED THE APPOINTMENT WAS DONE WITHOUT AWAITING THE STATE GOVT'S VIEWS

the Acting Chief Justice of the High Court here since June and is scheduled to be administered the oath as the High Court Chief Justice by the Governor here on Monday.

Hours before the oath ceremony, the Mann government convened an emergency meeting of the cabinet through video conferencing against the Centre's decision. The state Cabinet resolved that the appointment and administration of oath should be put on hold until Punjab's views are obtained and duly considered.

The Cabinet strongly condemned "another instance" of central government "bypassing" the state's constitutional rights and established proce-

dures, the statement said.

In a post on X in Punjabi after the meeting, Mann stated: "Today, the Punjab Cabinet unanimously passed an important resolution against the continued assault on Punjab's rights by the Central Government and the violation of constitutional norms.

"Appointing the new Chief Justice of the Punjab and Haryana High Court without obtaining the consent of the State Government is a direct violation of the prescribed procedures (Memorandum of Procedure) and constitutional norms." Mann, in his letters, requested urgent intervention in the matter by the President and the Prime Minister.

Mann said earlier the Centre withheld the State's Rs 9,000 crore Rural Development Fund (RDF) and flood relief package, changing the BBMB rules, "and now its direct interference in judicial appointments will not be tolerated".

Hry's BJP govt 'misleading' contractual workers: Hooda

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, September 6

Former Haryana Chief Minister and Leader of Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda on Sunday accused the BJP government of misleading sanitation workers and employees engaged through the Kaushal Nigam over their demand for regularisation.

Addressing a press conference in Rohtak, Hooda alleged that the government had made contradictory statements in the Assembly regarding contractual employees and falsely claimed that the previous Congress government had formulated a policy only for those completing 10 years of service.

Hooda produced two notifications issued during the Congress tenure, dated June 16 and June 18, 2014, which, he said, provided for regularisation of employees completing three years of service.

He claimed the policies had been upheld by the High Court and Supreme Court. According to Hooda, the BJP government subsequently sought to remove employees regularised under the Congress policy and prevent others from benefiting from it.

He also cited a notification issued by the Congress government in Himachal Pradesh providing for regularisation of contractual employees after two years of service. Hooda alleged that the BJP had promised Kaushal Nigam workers regularisation until retirement during elections but later described the arrangement as temporary.

Briefs

Pb: Gurpreet Sekhon joins AAP

CHANDIGARH: At a massive gathering in Zira, Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann welcomed Gurpreet Singh Sekhon into the AAP along with thousands of his supporters, saying the overwhelming public response reflects people's growing faith in politics of performance over the empty rhetoric of traditional parties.

Saini pays tribute to Tulsidas

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday hailed Goswami Tulsidas as a visionary saint who spread Lord Ram's ideals through his writings. At a Tulsidas Jayanti event, Saini announced Rs 31 lakh for a Goswami Dharamshala in Hisar.

Manipur: 2 militants killed

IMPHAL: Two UKNA militants were killed and two others injured in a gunfight with Army and Assam Rifles personnel in Manipur's Churachandpur district, officials said. The encounter followed an intelligence-based operation at Phaibong village. Security forces had been monitoring a suspected UKNA camp before militants opened fire on troops.

Hry's development on fast track under double-engine govt: Saini

MPOST BUREAU
Bhiwani, September 6

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said on Sunday that the "double-engine" government is accelerating Haryana's development at a triple pace.

Addressing a "Vikas Sankalp" rally in Bawani Khera, Saini presented a detailed roadmap for the comprehensive development of the area.

On the occasion, Saini inaugurated and laid the foundation stones of seven development projects worth approximately Rs 78 crore.

Saini emphasised that the BJP's double-engine government, at both the Centre and in Haryana, is now driving the state's development at an accelerated pace.

Addressing the crowd, the chief minister reiterated his commitment to the bright future of Bawani Khera.

CM SAINI ADDRESSED A "VIKAS SANKALP" RALLY IN BAWANI KHERA ON SUNDAY

He highlighted that over the past 12 years, development works worth over Rs 1,446 crore have been completed in the Bawani Khera constituency, compared to only Rs 609.58 crore during the previous Congress government's 10-year tenure.

Saini pointed out several significant development initiatives in the area over the last 12 years. The Bhiwani-Hansi section of NH-148B has been completed at a cost of Rs 1,322 crore, while NH-709A was constructed for Rs 749 crore, he said.

The Bhiwani-Khark section of NH-709E has been converted into a four-lane road for Rs 169 crore. Doubling of the Manheru-Bawani Khera railway line is underway at a cost of Rs

413 crore, of which 12 kilometres of work has been completed.

Describing farmer welfare as the government's top priority, Saini noted that 24 crops are being procured at Minimum Support Price (MSP) in Haryana. So far, Rs 1,86,000 crore has been directly transferred to the accounts of 12 lakh farmers for crop procurement. Furthermore, in the past 12 years, farmers have received Rs 16,160 crore in compensation for crop losses, he said.

Saini also announced that under the policy of providing government jobs without "kharchi-parchi" (bribes or recommendations), more than 2 lakh youths have secured government employment in Haryana. With the new Haryana Progressive MSME Policy-2026, the government aims to attract an investment of Rs 55,000 crore and create over 5 lakh new job opportunities.

'India working to run hydrogen train at up to 110 km/hour'

Consultations underway to decide sections on which new hydrogen train could be operated: Rly Board CEO

MPOST BUREAU
Indore, September 6

The Indian Railways is working to operate the country's first hydrogen-powered train at speeds of up to 110 kmph after completing trials at 120 kmph, Railway Board Chairman and CEO Satish Kumar said on Sunday.

"The operational speed of the hydrogen train has so far been kept at 75 kmph. However, trials have been completed for a speed of 120 kmph. After that, efforts are now underway to operate it at a maximum speed of 110 kmph," Kumar told report-



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

ers in Indore.

He said consultations were underway with all stakeholders to decide the rail sections on which the new hydrogen train could be operated, with techni-

cal aspects and arrangements for fuel supply also being examined.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi had on July 17 flagged off India's first hydrogen-powered train,

which operates on the 89-km Jind-Sonipat route in Haryana.

Unlike conventional electric trains that draw power from overhead lines, the Hydrogen

Fuel Cell Trainset generates electricity on board through a chemical reaction between hydrogen and oxygen, with water vapour and heat as its only by-product. There is no combustion, smoke and tailpipe carbon emissions.

Kumar said the country's first Vande Bharat sleeper express was currently operating between Howrah and Kamakhya (Guwahati), while four more such trains had been completed and would be formally inaugurated in the coming days. The Railways is expected to receive 11 more Vande Bharat sleeper trains this year,

Kumar said.

As many as 200 Vande Bharat sleeper trains are being manufactured under the public-private partnership (PPP) model and each train would take around one to one-and-a-half years to be completed, he said.

According to the official, the Railways was planning to operate 100 to 125 special trains for the Simhashta festival to be held in Ujjain in 2028 and was strengthening infrastructure for the large religious gathering.

Kumar said steps were also being taken to address the problem of rats in trains, along with strength-

ening existing systems.

He said artificial intelligence (AI) was being integrated with CCTV cameras to enhance security at railway stations and on trains.

On the Rs 18,500-crore Indore-Mannad railway line, Kumar said land acquisition was progressing rapidly for the project, which was approved in the 2024-25 financial year.

The ambitious project is expected to be completed in four to five years, he said. Kumar reviewed several railway projects in and around Indore, including construction of various rail lines and redevelopment of Indore railway station.

KEY POINTS

- » PM Modi had on July 17 flagged off India's first hydrogen-powered train, which operates on the 89-km Jind-Sonipat route in Haryana
- » Hydrogen Fuel Cell Trainset generates electricity on board through a chemical reaction between hydrogen and oxygen, with water vapour and heat as its only by-product
- » There is no combustion, smoke and tailpipe carbon emissions

News at a glance

B'desh court grants bail to jailed Hindu rights leader

DHAKA: Bangladesh's High Court on Sunday granted bail to jailed Hindu rights leader Chinmoy Krishna Das in two more cases, but his release is unlikely as he faces charges in other cases, local media reported.

Das was also granted bail in two cases last month involving vandalism, attack and obstruction of government duty. The Hindu monk was arrested in November 2024 on sedition charges for allegedly disrespecting the national flag, which sparked protests and communal tensions.

US envoys arrive in Kyiv after talks with Putin in Moscow

KYIV: US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner arrived in Kyiv on Sunday in their first official visit to Ukraine as part of a renewed push for peace after Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

Their trip follows a meeting with Russian President Vladimir Putin in Moscow on Saturday, seeking to revive peace talks during escalating aerial attacks by both sides. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Sunday that Kyiv is ready for a "constructive" discussion with US representatives.

Pakistan's DyPM Dar meets Saudi, Turkiye, Egypt FMs

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan's Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar on Sunday held separate telephone conversations with his counterparts from Saudi Arabia, Turkiye and Egypt, discussing bilateral and regional issues.

The Foreign Office (FO) said Dar held telephonic talks with Saudi Foreign Minister Faisal bin Farhan, Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan and Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty. In his call with the Saudi foreign minister, the two leaders discussed regional and global developments.



Children dressed as angels walk during 'Little Angels' Parade' in Bucharest on Sunday AP/PTI

Briefs

Mt. Anak Krakatau erupts

JAKARTA: Indonesia's Anak Krakatau volcano erupted early Sunday, prompting the cancellation of all flights at Jakarta's Soekarno-Hatta International Airport as volcanic ash drifted across parts of western Indonesia.

Indonesia's Geological Agency said the volcanic island located in Indonesia's Sunda Strait between the main Java and Sumatra islands had showed signs of activity since Friday before erupting for 30 seconds at 3:53 a.m. Sunday. The agency's closed-circuit camera showed lava flares at the mountain.

There were no casualties reported and no evacuation order issued. The nearest settlement is more than 16 kilometers (10 miles).

German exit polls out

MAGDEBURG: The Alternative for Germany party has a strong lead in a regional election, but it is unclear whether it will be able to form the country's first far-right state government since World War II, exit polls indicated Sunday.

Alternative for Germany, or AfD, went into the vote in the eastern state of Saxony-Anhalt seeking an absolute majority in the state legislature to govern on its own. That would overcome the so-called "firewall" of mainstream parties' refusal to work with AfD.

Typhoon Saudel hit China; 3 dead

BEIJING: The death toll from a mudslide in eastern China rose to three on Sunday after days of torrential rain brought by Typhoon Saudel. Nine others were still missing.

The mudslide hit part of a village in Suichuan County in Jiangxi province early Saturday, damaging a dozen houses. Rescuers found two people dead Sunday, state broadcaster CCTV reported. Over 5,300 people in the country were relocated to safer places. Separately, CCTV reported that two people were killed in Hunan province following downpours.

EXPERTS CALLED IT A DANGEROUS ESCALATION

Iran claims strike on US ship in Strait of Hormuz; US denies

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Cairo, September 6

Iran said Sunday it struck an unmanned US vessel trying to enter the Strait of Hormuz, a claim that the US military dismissed as a "total lie."

The purported attack came a day after the US military said forces struck three Iranian oil tankers in response to Navy warships being targeted with ballistic missiles. Experts called it a dangerous escalation after Iran's previous attacks at sea targeted commercial shipping.

The war began with US and Israeli attacks on Iran on February 28. But since a fragile ceasefire agreement was announced in June, on-and-off fighting has persisted, with both sides trying to inflict military and economic pain as negotiations have collapsed.

The United States and Iran resumed attacks last week, following a month of relative calm, with the Strait of Hormuz and areas along Iran's southern coast again being targeted. At least five people were killed earlier in the week during a US bombardment that returned attention to the area where a school was hit in the war's opening strikes.



Firefighters work at the scene after a fuel tanker struck several vehicles and burst into flames near Sanandaj, western Iran AP/PTI

The Trump administration appears to have adopted a dual-prong approach to the conflict, responding militarily to attacks on the strait while going after foreign financial institutions that handle Iran's money.

But Tehran's hard-line new senior leaders have signalled a willingness to dig in after weathering decades of sanctions. Iran has found ways over the years to circumvent sanctions, and now a US block-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The United States and Iran resumed attacks last week
- » Iran has found ways over the years to circumvent sanctions
- » The war began with US and Israeli attacks on Iran on Feb 28

ade of its ports, and get its oil to buyers to help ease growing economic pressures. That relies in part on a shadow fleet transporting its oil.

Tehran's new leverage

focuses on the Strait of Hormuz that is crucial to global oil and natural gas shipments.

It was seen as an international waterway before the war began.

Six civilians killed by militants in Balochistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Karachi, September 4

Six civilians have been killed by militants in Pakistan's restive Balochistan province, local police said on Sunday.

The bullet-riddled bodies of six civilians have been found in Balochistan's Mastung district on Sunday, official said.

Trump admin makes another plea to allow mail ballot curbs

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Washington, September 6

The Trump administration on Sunday renewed its appeal to the Supreme Court after a federal judge blocked new restrictions on mail ballots ahead of the midterms.

The filing came after US District Court Judge Indira Talwani extended an order against the Postal Service enforcing President Donald Trump's executive order for the November elections.

LEGAL WRANGLING COMES EVEN AS STATES START SENDING OUT MAIL BALLOTS

The legal wrangling comes even as states start sending out mail ballots, leaving the administration little time to make big changes in mail ballot rules.

"Ballots have already begun to be mailed in North Carolina,

and more States will begin the mailing process as the injunction remains in place – including Alabama on September 9 and at least five States the week of September 13," Solicitor General John Sauer said in the filing.

The appeal marks the third time the administration has asked the high court to intervene.

The high court has allowed the plan to move forward but not ruled on whether it is legal.

'Shameful, Nasty': Singapore minister slams racist posts targeting Indians

Country must never allow prejudice against any community: PM

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Singapore, September 6

Singapore must never allow prejudice against any community to become accepted or normalised, Prime Minister Lawrence Wong said on Sunday, days after racist and xenophobic comments appeared online about the Nepal-Tibet flash floods disaster and the Singapore Airlines-Air India partnership.



Singapore PM Lawrence Wong

"We can and should have robust debates. But

we should never use seemingly legitimate arguments as a cover to fuel prejudice against any community or hostility towards foreigners," the Channel News Asia quoted Wong as saying.

The prime minister's remarks come a day after Singapore Senior Minister K Shanmugam said police are investigating "shameful" and "totally unacceptable" racist and

xenophobic comments posted online about the Nepal-Tibet flood disaster and Singapore Airlines' (SIA) investment in Air India. In a Facebook post, Wong said that "an uglier side" had emerged in online discussions about the two matters.

Racist comments surfaced online targeting some of the nine Singaporeans missing in the Nepal-Tibet disaster.

From bank queues to QR codes: Nepal's digital shift in philanthropy

By the 11th day after the floods, over NPR 10bn had reportedly been collected in the relief fund

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kathmandu, September 6

Once, donating to government relief funds in Nepal meant carrying cash, finding a bank and standing in a queue. Now, for many, it takes just a phone, a few taps and a QR code scan.

For guitarist Bobby Lama of the band Mongolian Heart, the change was personal.

During the 2015 earthquake and the COVID-19 pandemic, Lama joined rescue and relief efforts, carrying cash himself to communities in need. The hassle of going to a bank meant he never considered donating to a government relief fund.

This time, after devastating floods hit the Himalayan nation, he simply scanned a QR code and sent money directly to the Prime Minister's Disaster Relief Fund through mobile banking, accord-



Nepal Police personnel conduct search and rescue operation following the flash floods in Nepal PTI

ing to The Kathmandu Post newspaper.

Lama's experience reflects a broader shift in the way Nepal is responding to disasters, with the country's rapidly expanding digital payments infrastructure connecting ordinary citizens, businesses and overseas donors directly with a government relief fund. By the 11th day after

the devastating August 26 Bhotekoshi floods, more than NPR 10 billion had been collected in the relief fund, the Post report said.

The contributions have ranged from schoolchildren to global tech giant Nvidia.

The campaign marks the first time in Nepal that individuals have been able to make direct person-to-person transactions.

KIND ATTENTION RAIL PASSENGERS! IMPORTANT INFORMATION

EXTENSION OF PERIODICITY, INTRODUCTION & PROVISION OF ADDITIONAL STOPPAGES OF SPECIAL TRAINS

This is notified for the information of Rail Passengers that Railways have decided to extend the Periodicity of the run, introduce and provide additional stoppages at nominated station of following Special Trains as under:-

Train No.	Station		Frequency/ Days of Run	Earlier Notified Upto	Extended Period upto	Trips
	From	To				
05579	Purnia Court	Anand Vihar Terminal	Bi-Weekly (Fri, Sun)	30.08.2026	29.11.2026	26
05580	Anand Vihar Terminal	Purnia Court	Bi-Weekly (Sun, Tue)	01.09.2026	01.12.2026	26
05575	Saharsa Jn.	Anand Vihar Terminal	Weekly (Tuesday)	25.08.2026	24.11.2026	12
05576	Anand Vihar Terminal	Saharsa Jn.	Weekly (Thursday)	27.08.2026	26.11.2026	12
02397	Gaya Jn.	Anand Vihar Terminal	Weekly (Sunday)	26.07.2026	29.11.2026	13
02398	Anand Vihar Terminal	Gaya Jn.	Weekly (Monday)	27.07.2026	30.11.2026	13
03639	Dhanbad Jn.	Shakurbasti	Bi-Weekly (Mon, Fri)	31.08.2026	30.11.2026	26
03640	Shakurbasti	Dhanbad Jn.	Bi-Weekly (Tue, Sat)	01.09.2026	01.12.2026	26

05219/05220 Muzaffarpur Jn. - Anand Vihar Terminal - Muzaffarpur Jn. 24 Trips

Train No. 05219		STATIONS	Train No. 05220	
ARR.	DEP.		ARR.	DEP.
----	13:30	Muzaffarpur Jn.	09:45	----
10:00	----	Anand Vihar Terminal	----	12:00

DAYS OF RUN: 05219 Ex. Muzaffarpur Jn. from 11.09.2026 to 27.11.2026 and 05220 Ex. Anand Vihar Terminal from 12.09.2026 to 28.11.2026.

STOPPAGES: Hajipur Jn., Sonpur, Patliputra, Danapur, Ara, Buxar, Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Jn., Prayagraj Jn., Govindpur and Tundla Jn. Stations.

ACCOMMODATION: AC 2 Tier & AC 3 Tier Economy.

Additional Stoppages of Special Train at Tundla Jn. with immediate effect

Train No. & Train Name	Station	Arr.	Dep.
03639 Dhanbad Jn. - Shakurbasti Express Special	Tundla Jn.	12:13	12:15
03640 Shakurbasti - Dhanbad Jn. Express Special	Tundla Jn.	03:30	03:32

Note:- Train No. 02397 will depart from Gaya Jn. at 14:15 hrs. instead of Sheikhpura and Arrive Anand Vihar Terminal at 11:40 Hrs. & Train No. 02398 will depart from Anand Vihar Terminal at 13:30 hrs. & Terminate at Gaya Jn. at 11:15 hrs. instead of Sheikhpura. Timing between Gaya Jn. - Anand Vihar Terminal - Gaya Jn. will remain same.

For detailed information regarding stoppages and timings of above trains, please call RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or visit enquiry website www.enquiry.indianrail.gov.in

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SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Govt mulling liberalising FDI in plantation sector: Official

At present, 100% FDI via automatic route is allowed in tea, coffee, rubber, cardamom, palm & olive plantations

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 6

The government is considering liberalising foreign direct investment (FDI) norms in the plantation sector by bringing more commercial crops under the ambit, an official said.

The Commerce and Industry Ministry is holding stakeholder consultations on the issue, the official said.

“We are looking for more FDI liberalisation in the plantation sector like banana,” the official added.

At present, 100 per cent FDI under automatic route is permitted in the tea sector, including tea plantations, coffee, rubber, cardamom, palm and olive oil tree plantations.

Besides these, FDI is not allowed in any other plantation sector/activity.

India has received \$295.23 million FDI in tea and coffee (processing and warehousing coffee), and \$3.93 billion in rubber



goods during April 2000 and March 2026.

As per estimates, India is the largest banana producer in the world with over 30 million tonnes annually.

Despite being the largest global producer of bananas, India's exports do not reflect this quantitative evaluation. India's export share in the global market is only 1 per cent even though the country accounts for 26.45 per cent of the world's banana pro-

duction (35.36 million metric tons).

In 2024-25, India exported bananas worth \$377.5 million, about 30 per cent year-on-year growth. India is targeting to increase it to \$1 billion in the coming years.

The major export destinations for Indian bananas include Iran, Iraq, UAE, Oman, Uzbekistan, Saudi Arabia, Nepal, Qatar, Kuwait, Bahrain, Afghanistan, and the Maldives.

Additionally, the US,

KEY POINTS

» India has received \$295.23 million FDI in tea and coffee (processing and warehousing coffee), and \$3.93 billion in rubber goods during April 2000 and March 2026

» Despite being the largest global producer of bananas, India's export share in the global market is only 1% even though the country accounts for 26.45% of the world's banana production

Russia, Japan, Germany, China, the Netherlands, the UK, and France present India with abundant export opportunities.

Banana is a major horticultural produce, with Andhra Pradesh being the largest banana-producing state in India, followed by Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, and Uttar Pradesh. These five states collectively contribute around 67 per cent to India's banana production in 2022-23.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 6

After investing in Indian equities for two consecutive months, foreign investors turned net sellers in the first week of September, pulling out Rs 7,443 crore as a rebound in crude oil prices, rising US bond yields, and a firm dollar dented risk appetite.

The outflow came after Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) infused over Rs 29,600 crore in August and Rs 20,200 crore in July, data from National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL) showed.

Before that, they had remained net sellers for four straight months from March to June.

With the latest withdrawal, the total outflow by foreign portfolio investors from Indian equities climbed to Rs 2.32 lakh crore so far in 2026, surpassing the Rs 1.66 lakh crore withdrawn during the entire year 2025, the



THE LATEST WITHDRAWAL SURPASSED RS 1.66 LAKH CRORE WITHDRAWN DURING THE ENTIRE YEAR 2025

data showed.

According to NSDL data, FPIs withdrew Rs 7,443 crore from Indian equities in the first week of the month, till September 4.

Rajkumar Rathi, Chief Investment Officer at YES Securities, said the recent selling was driven by a rebound in crude oil prices, which has raised concerns over India's inflation and current account outlook.

HIGHLIGHTS

» Foreign investors also extended their selling to the debt market during the period under review

» They withdrew Rs 377 crore through the Fully Accessible Route (FAR) and Rs 231 crore through the Voluntary Retention Route (VRR)

» Meanwhile, they invested Rs 217 crore through the general route during the period under review

“Further strengthening US bond yields and a firm dollar index have reduced foreign risk appetite for emerging markets,” he said.

Rathi also pointed to India's premium equity valuations, particularly in growth sectors and the mid- and small-cap segments, as factors prompting foreign funds to book profits and rebalance portfolios.

However, he said for-

eign investor appetite for India's primary market has remained “structurally resilient”.

“As seen in early September, the pipeline of upcoming IPOs will continue to act as a distinct sponge for foreign capital. If companies price their primary offerings attractively, it will structurally sustain primary market FPI inflows, even if the secondary market faces net selling,” Rathi said.

Looking ahead, global bond yields are likely to remain a key driver of FPI flows, V K Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit Investments, said.

Foreign investors also extended their selling to the debt market during the period under review. They withdrew Rs 377 crore through the Fully Accessible Route (FAR) and Rs 231 crore through the Voluntary Retention Route (VRR). Meanwhile, they invested Rs 217 crore through the general route.

US inflation data, crude oil & Iran conflict to steer bullion this week

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi, September 6

Upcoming US inflation figures, crude oil price movements, and geopolitical tensions in West Asia will be primary triggers for gold and silver prices, amid heightened speculation surrounding the global interest rate outlook, analysts said.

Investors will also keep an eye on consumer price data from Germany and China, GDP figures from the Eurozone, Japan and the UK, as well as China's trade data this week, they added.

Last week, gold futures for October delivery fell Rs 3,514, or 2.2 per cent, to Rs 1.52 lakh per 10 grams, while silver declined Rs 4,786, or nearly 2 per cent, to Rs 2.37 lakh per kg on the MCX.

“MCX gold witnessed volatile moves this week, with the first half seeing continued profit booking following last Friday's correction after the Fed indicated the possibility of a rate hike,” Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst - Commodity & Currency, LKP Securities, said.

In global markets, Comex gold futures for December delivery slipped \$53.3, or nearly 1.2 per cent, to end the week at \$4,476.6 per ounce. Silver dipped by 1.52 per cent to \$66.75 per ounce in New York.

Jitendra Singh calls for greater support for non-metro startups

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 6

Union Minister of State for Science & Technology Dr Jitendra Singh on Sunday called for a systematic shift in how India nurtures its startup ecosystem, arguing that nearly 60 per cent of the country's startups operate outside major metropolitan centres and deserve institutional backing equal to that of their metro-based counterparts.

Addressing the sixth RISE Conclave inaugural session in Kolkata, Singh

Domestic funds seize 74% of India's private credit mkt, investors turn bullish on growth

ANI NEWS

New Delhi, September 6

India's private credit market is likely to remain on a growth trajectory over the next one to two years, even as competition among lenders intensifies, with domestic funds increasingly expected to drive deployment and target larger transactions, according to a research report by EY.

The shift is already visible in the first half of 2026. Private credit deals tracked by EY totalled \$3.5 billion in H1 2026, marginally higher than \$3.4 billion in the second half of 2025.

Domestic private credit

players accounted for 74 per cent of total deal value and around 79 per cent of deal count, significantly strengthening their position against global funds.

EY said domestic funds are benefiting from their local presence and access to mid-market borrowers and are increasingly participating in larger transactions as well.

Global funds' share of private credit deal value fell to 26 per cent in H1 2026 from 36 per cent in H2 2025 and 68 per cent in H1 2025.

The market's underlying demand remains broad-based. Refinancing, real estate project fund-

ing, HoldCo funding and acquisition financing were among the key purposes for which private credit was deployed during the period.

EY's private credit pulse survey also found that stress-related situations, capital expenditure and Mergers & Acquisitions (M&A) financing were emerging as important sources of demand.

Investor sentiment remains constructive. EY's survey showed 60 per cent of respondents were bullish on private credit over the next one to two years, while another 13 per cent were very bullish and 27 per cent were

cautious.

Sectorally, real estate remained the largest recipient, accounting for around 35 per cent of deal value, followed by healthcare at 13 per cent and food and beverages at 12 per cent. Food and beverages gained particular momentum during the period.

With domestic funds gaining scale, a deeper deal pipeline and demand for flexible financing solutions, EY expects private credit to remain an important component of India's evolving credit ecosystem, although lenders will need to navigate rising competition and selective risk-taking.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi, September 6

The GST Council meeting, originally scheduled for September 12, has been postponed to October 7 on account of the BRICS summit.

Sources said in view of the BRICS summit, the 57th GST Council meeting has been rescheduled for October 7. The meeting will be preceded by an officers' meeting on October 5 and 6.

The council, chaired by Sitharaman and comprising state finance ministers, would be meeting after a gap of over a year.

The 56th GST Council meeting had taken place



July 1, 2017.

At its 57th meeting on October 7, 2026, the GST Council is likely to discuss simplification in GST registration of businesses that pass on tax credit of over Rs 2.5 lakh a month.

Also, automation and other changes in GST registration cancellation is also expected to be taken up by the council.

Currently, there is no uniformity in the procedure followed by the central GST formation and various state formations in granting GST registration to large businesses who pass on credit over Rs 2.5 lakh/month and this creates uncertainty in the minds of taxpayers.

HZL's 3rd Vedanta Zinc City Half Marathon draws 9,700+ runners

MPOST BUREAU

Udaipur, September 6

Hindustan Zinc Ltd (HZL) hosted the third edition of the Vedanta Zinc City Half Marathon in Udaipur, attracting more than 9,700 runners across on-ground and virtual formats, nearly 45 per cent higher than the previous edition.

Touted as 'India's Most Beautiful Marathon', the event featured 21.097-km, 10-km and 5-km categories, drawing participants from India and overseas, including elite ath-

letes, first-time runners, senior citizens, women's fitness groups, corporate teams and specially-abled participants.

A special Champions Race saw participation from rural Rajasthan, Udaipur communities and students of Hindustan Zinc's Shiksha Sambal initiative.

The marathon also promoted voter participation ahead of Rajasthan's municipal elections and supported the #RunForZeroHunger initiative.

Runners competed

against the backdrop of Fateh Sagar Lake and the Aravalli ranges. Mukesh Kumar won the men's half marathon in 1 hour, 8 minutes and 47 seconds, while Pooja topped the women's category in 1 hour, 26 minutes and 9 seconds.

In the 10-km race, Tehender won the men's title in 32 minutes and 1 second, while Kumari Parrru finished first among women in 36 minutes and 49 seconds.

The AIMS-certified marathon is listed on the global marathon calendar.

ANI NEWS

New Delhi, September 6

Indian equity markets could see stronger activity ahead as trading volumes recover, while a favourable outcome from the SEBI's review of the Closing Auction Session (CAS) methodology could support BSE's average daily premium turnover value (ADPTV) at Rs 220-230 billion, according to a Nuvama Institutional Equities report.

The average daily premium turnover value is the total amount of option premiums actually paid by traders divided by the number of trading days in

a specific period.

Nuvama noted, BSE's average daily premium turnover value (ADPTV) stood at Rs 228 billion, up 18.4 per cent week-on-week, compared with an 18.1 per cent rise for the industry and against its remaining FY2026-27 estimate of Rs 186 billion.

At the same time, the average daily contracts traded declined 3.1 per cent week-on-week to 115 million, compared with 98 million in August 2026 and 150 million in July 2026.

However, premium per contract increased 22.2 per cent week-on-week to Rs 1,986, from Rs 1,897 in

August and Rs 1,688 in July.

“Overall it resulted in a premium per contract of INR1,986 (+22.2 per cent WoW) versus INR1,897/1,688 for Aug26/Jul-26. BSE ADPTV MS at 35.0 per cent (+6.9 bp WoW),” the report said.

For FY2026-27 to date, BSE's ADPTV stood at around Rs 265 billion, with an ADPTV market share of approximately 35.2 per cent and a premium-to-notional turnover ratio of about 12.4 basis points, compared with 17.2 basis points for the industry.

Against this backdrop, Nuvama highlighted, “Vol-

umes rebounded sharply and SEBI's upcoming review of CAS methodology,” stressing that a “favourable revision could lift ADPTV back to the INR 220-230 billion range.”

The market regulator said on earlier that it may propose changes to the methodology for determining settlement prices for derivative contracts, following feedback from market participants on using CAS-based closing prices for expiry settlements.

A consultation paper on the proposed changes is expected to be released within about a week.

Paint makers expect healthy FY27 demand

Asian Paints, Berger Paints, Kansai Nerolac and JSW Dulux expect demand from housing, infra & automotive sectors to remain supportive

AGENCIES

New Delhi, September 6

Leading paint manufacturers expect double-digit growth to continue through the festive season, despite fresh price hikes to offset input-cost pressures. However, intense competition across price segments and uncertainty over crude-linked raw material costs remain key concerns.

Asian Paints, Berger Paints, Kansai Nerolac and

CLOSER LOOK

» Berger Paints and JSW Dulux are targeting double-digit growth, while Asian Paints expects 8-10 per cent volume growth in FY27

» Meanwhile, competition has intensified with new entrants including Birla Opus, JSW Paints and Haisha Paints

JSW Dulux expect demand from housing, infrastructure and automotive sectors to remain supportive.

Berger Paints and JSW Dulux are targeting double-digit growth, while Asian

Paints expects 8-10 per cent volume growth in FY27.

Asian Paints MD and CEO Amit Syngle said demand remained “decent” in the June quarter and the company

expects volume growth of 8-10 per cent through FY27. The company reported a 39.6 per cent rise in consolidated net profit to Rs 1,559.45 crore, while revenue increased 18 per cent to Rs 10,541.94 crore.

Berger Paints MD and CEO Abhijit Roy expects double-digit revenue growth in FY27, supported by the full-quarter impact of price hikes. He pegged Q2 volume growth at 7.5-8 per cent, alongside

a 7.5-8.59 per cent price increase. Kansai Nerolac expects further price hikes of around 3 per cent in decorative paints and 3-5 per cent in industrial paints.

JSW Dulux also expects double-digit volume and value growth, citing strong festive demand.

Meanwhile, competition has intensified with new entrants including JSW Paints, Pidilite with Haisha Paints, and Grasm with its Birla Opus.

IN FY26 INDIA EXPORTED 61.5 MT OF PETROLEUM PRODUCTS

India emerges as key diesel supplier to Europe as Russian, US flows falter

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 6

India has emerged as a crucial source of diesel for Europe, supplying about 60 per cent of the fuel transiting the Bab-el-Mandeb to the region in August, as Russian exports remain severely constrained and US shipments begin to weaken, according to data from Vortexa - real-time data and advanced analytics for energy and freight. About 2,00,000 barrels per day (bpd) of diesel (gasoil) transited the Bab-el-Mandeb in August on vessels bound for Europe, close to year-earlier levels after flows through the key shipping route nearly stalled in March and April. India supplied roughly 60 per cent of that volume, making Indian refineries an increasingly important source of Europe's eastern diesel supply, Vortexa said in a report. India is the world's fourth-largest refiner, with an installed capacity of 258.1 million tonnes per annum, which exceeds



domestic fuel demand by a margin. In 2025-26 (April 2025 to March 2026 fiscal year), India exported 61.5 million tonnes (MT) of petroleum products, making it one of the largest exporters of refined products globally. These fuels are now finding a market in Europe and Russia. The concern is whether that flow can be maintained. Crude and condensate shipments into India fell for a second consecutive month to about 3.8 million barrels per day in August, compared to 4.8 million barrels per day a year earlier, Vortexa data showed. Russian diesel exports,

once a major source of European supply, have remained largely absent. Russia's seaborne diesel and gasoil exports averaged only about 1,50,000 barrels per day in the first 25 days of August, down about 6,10,000 barrels per day from a year earlier and 81 per cent below the five-year seasonal average, according to Vortexa. Even a lifting or partial relaxation of Russia's diesel export ban from September 1 may not produce a rapid recovery. Ukrainian drone strikes have continued to disrupt Russian refining and export infrastructure, with 32 attacks on refineries recorded across July

KEY POINTS

- » About 2,00,000 bpd of diesel transited the Bab-el-Mandeb in August on vessels bound for Europe
- » India supplied roughly 60 per cent of that volume, making Indian refineries an increasingly important source of Europe's eastern diesel supply

and August. An attack on the 2,60,000-barrel-per-day Perm refinery left only about 28 per cent of its crude distillation capacity operational, according to data cited by Vortexa. The impact extends to export terminals. The Black Sea accounted for about 44 per cent, or 380,000 barrels per day, of Russia's diesel and gasoil exports last year, but port and refinery disruptions have reduced available volumes. No diesel cargoes have been exported from Tuapse since a May strike, according to Vortexa. The port handled about 90,000 barrels per day, or roughly 10 per cent of Rus-

sia's total diesel exports, in 2025. Russia is also increasingly turning to imports to compensate for domestic refining disruptions. Its seaborne gasoline imports surged to a record roughly 1,25,000 barrels per day in August, equivalent to about 4,70,000 tonnes for the month. Around 55 per cent of those imports arrived on sanctioned tonnage, while India, Turkey and Morocco were among the suppliers. Indian gasoline (petrol) cargoes to Russia in August were carried on sanctioned fleets and involved ship-to-ship transfers in the Mediterranean, highlighting how flows of refined products in and out of the region are being reshaped by sanctions, refinery outages and disruptions to conventional trade routes. For Europe, however, India's role is most important on the diesel side. The country is filling part of the gap left by Russia at a time when the US, Europe's other major source of incremental supply, is also showing signs of retreat.

OPEC+ keeps its oil production policy unchanged for October

The meeting of OPEC+ members comes as the Iran war continues to limit group's influence over prices

REUTERS
Dubai, September 6

OPEC+ kept its oil output policy unchanged for October at a meeting on Sunday, it said in a statement, as the producer group needs to agree new quotas before deciding its next output steps. The meeting of seven core OPEC+ members - Saudi Arabia, Russia, Iraq, Kuwait, Algeria, Kazakhstan and Oman - comes as the Iran war continues to disrupt oil exports through the Strait of Hormuz, limiting OPEC+'s influence over prices and market share. In August, OPEC+ agreed its production boost for September, completing a phased rollback of a 1.65 million-barrel-per-day supply cut first agreed in 2023. Despite the agreed production increases, the group made up of the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and its allies, including Russia, still produces far below its targets because of the war. OPEC'S POWER LIMITED BY IRAN CONFLICT "OPEC+ currently has



very limited power over the physical oil market," said Jorge Leon of Rystad Energy. "The group can change production targets on paper, but it cannot guarantee that those barrels will be produced or actually reach the market." "The focus now shifts away from monthly production adjustments and towards the much more consequential debate over 2027." OPEC+ still has another layer of production cuts in place, covering most members of the 21-country group until the end of 2026. Before the group decides how to unwind the cuts and return production to the market, it

needs to review members' oil production capacity to set 2027 output baselines, which form the basis for quotas. This debate will likely happen later in 2026 and hence OPEC+ is likely to pause its output increases for the fourth quarter, sources earlier told Reuters. The statement on Sunday made no mention of policy beyond October. Only the seven OPEC+ members who met on Sunday, plus the United Arab Emirates until it left OPEC in May, have been involved in monthly output decisions in recent years. The seven countries will hold their next meeting on October 4.

West Asia conflict, crude oil prices, US inflation data to steer stock market: Analysts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, September 6

Developments in the West Asia conflict, crude oil prices & US inflation data would be the major drivers for the stock market this week, according to analysts. Trading activities of foreign investors & global market trends will also influence domestic equities. "This week is expected to remain highly sensitive to global monetary policy, crude oil prices and geopolitical developments. Investors will closely monitor the impact of the stronger-than-expected US employment data on expectations regarding the Federal Reserve's September policy decision," Ajit Mishra - SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said. On the domestic front, investors will continue to monitor foreign institutional flows, the rupee, crude oil prices and domestic liquidity, he added. Brent crude gained more than 8 per cent during the week, while WTI crude rose over 9 per cent, as renewed US-Iran hostilities and concerns surrounding the Strait of Hormuz increased the geopolitical risk premium in global energy markets, Ponnudi R, CEO - Enrich Money, said.

Govt shortlists 7 candidates for 2nd round interview for ONGC top job

AGENCIES
New Delhi, September 6

Seven candidates shortlisted for the top job at state-run Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) are likely to appear before a search-cum-selection committee this week as the government moves to choose a successor to Chairman and Managing Director Arun Kumar Singh, people familiar with the process said. The second round follows the screening of 18 applicants on August 18, after which the field was narrowed to seven. The shortlisted candidates include Oil India Ltd Chairman and Managing Direc-

tor Ranjit Rath, 54, seen as a frontrunner; ONGC Videsh Ltd MD Rajarshi Gupta, 59; ONGC Director (Technology and Field Services) Vikram Saxena; Director (Strategy and Corporate Affairs) Satyam Kumar; OVL Director (Operations) Dulal Halder; MRPL Director (Finance) Devendra Kumar; and Indian Oil Corporation Director (Marketing) SP Shrivastava. The selection has drawn attention following a one-off relaxation in the age criterion, allowing candidates up to 59 years against the earlier 58-year limit. Gupta's shortlisting has also raised questions as he will

be about 59 years and five months old on December 7, when Singh's extended tenure ends. The three-member committee comprises the Public Enterprises Selection Board chairperson, oil secretary and a former Indian Oil chairman as an outside expert. Rath is making a second attempt at the ONGC top job after being shortlisted last year, when Singh's tenure was extended by a year. The selected chairman will oversee ONGC's exploration, production, profitability, new-energy and petrochemical expansion, acquisitions and technology adoption.

AGENCIES
New Delhi, September 6

State Bank of India (SBI) plans to hire around 11,000-12,000 personnel and add about 200-250 branches on a net basis in the current financial year, Chairman C S Setty said. "We would be looking at around 11,000 to 12,000 appointments across both clerical and officer cadres this year," Setty said, adding that the number could vary depending on retirements and emerging requirements. Hiring is expected to be lower than last year, when SBI recruited 1,500 specialist IT officers.



SBI had more than 2.45 lakh employees as of March 2026 and hired 25,633 people in FY2025-26, including 4,640 officers, 19,340 associates and 1,653 contractual staff, according to its annual report. On branch expansion, Setty said State Bank of India still has "white

space" in several areas, including new residential colonies and commercially active districts. After rationalising some branches, the lender expects its network to grow by 200-250 branches annually on a net basis. Setty also said SBI and its subsidiary SBI Capital Markets Ltd plan to sell up to 1 per cent of their combined stake in the National Stock Exchange (NSE) through its proposed Rs 30,000-crore IPO. SBI plans to divest 0.65 per cent and SBI Capital Markets 0.35 per cent, although the final sale could be lower if other shareholders participate.

SBI currently holds 3.23 per cent in NSE, while SBI Capital Markets owns 4.33 per cent. The NSE recently received regulatory approval for its proposed IPO, which could become India's largest-ever public offering, surpassing Hyundai Motor India's Rs 27,858.75-crore issue in 2024. Setty said there are no immediate plans to monetise other subsidiaries. In July, State Bank of India and Amundi diluted around 10 per cent of their stake in SBI Mutual Fund, raising Rs 11,675 crore through the fund house's IPO.

NMDC to start commercial thermal coal output in Q3, targets 1 MT sales in FY27

AGENCIES
New Delhi, September 6

State-owned NMDC will commence commercial production of thermal coal in the October-December quarter and aims to sell up to 1 MT of the fuel in FY27, Chairman Amitava Mukherjee said. The Hyderabad-based miner, under the Ministry of Steel, currently meets around 20 per cent of India's iron ore requirement. Mukherjee said NMDC has drawn up a



roadmap through 2030 to diversify beyond iron ore and support the government's Viksit Bharat vision. "We are 99.9 per cent an iron ore company. We aim

to help the growing industries in the country with maximum of their mineral needs," he said, adding that the company has reached the coal seam at its Tokisud North mine in Jharkhand, with production expected to begin next quarter. NMDC will also develop the Rohne coking coal block in FY27, targeting production as early as FY28. Tokisud North has reserves of 52 MT and a peak rated capacity of 2.3 MT annually, while Rohne has 191 MT of reserves and

an 8 MT peak capacity. Mukherjee aims to make NMDC India's largest mineral mining company and generate at least 20 per cent of revenue from minerals other than iron ore by 2030. NMDC reported record revenue of Rs 31,554 crore in FY26, up 33 per cent from Rs 23,668 crore in FY25. It produced a record 53 MT of iron ore in FY26, up 20 per cent, and remains on track to reach 100 MT annual production by 2030.

Ashish Chauhan says fully committed to NSE, denies Tata Sons top job buzz

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, September 6

NSE MD and CEO Ashish-kumar Chauhan has denied reports that he is being considered for the position of Tata Sons Chairman, saying he remains "fully committed" to his responsibilities at the exchange and its ongoing IPO and listing process. The NSE, in a clarification on Sunday, said media reports and market rumours suggesting that Chauhan is under consideration for the Tata Sons

chairman's position "are not based on any information available with the exchange". "Chauhan has categorically denied such reports and confirmed that they are speculative and factually incorrect," NSE said. According to the exchange, Chauhan has confirmed that "he remains fully committed to his responsibilities at NSE and to the ongoing IPO & listing process of the Company". The clarification came in reference to a report titled "Tata Sons succession

race narrows to Narendran, Agarwal; Chauhan emerges as dark horse" dated September 5. People familiar with the matter said that Tata Sons, the holding company of the \$275-billion-plus Tata conglomerate, has narrowed its search for a successor to Chairman N Chandrasekaran to three prominent corporate leaders - Tata Steel CEO and MD T V Narendran, Tata Sons Executive Director and Group CFO Saurabh Agrawal, and NSE MD and CEO Ashish Chauhan.

Hyundai Motor expects 30% sales from rural markets in next 3-4 years

AGENCIES
New Delhi, September 6

Hyundai Motor India Ltd expects rural markets to account for around 30 per cent of its total sales over the next three to four years as it expands its presence beyond urban centres, Managing Director and CEO Tarun Garg said. Rural contribution rose to 25.9 per cent of the company's sales in the first quarter of FY27 from 22.6 per cent a year earlier. Rural sales grew 23 per cent in the quarter, compared with 2.8 per cent growth in urban markets.



Garg said the company's confidence in rural demand is supported by improving road infrastructure, affordable data and rising access to product information. SUVs, which account for 68 per cent of Hyundai's overall sales, have a 69 per cent penetration in its rural markets.

Hyundai is also strengthening its rural network, with six out of every 10 new outlets being opened in such markets. The company has more than 100 mobile service vans dedicated to rural areas. HMIL sold 2,47,980 units domestically between April and August, up 12.6 per cent from 2,20,233 units in the year-ago period. The automaker expects its rural opportunity to grow further with two upcoming products—a midsize SUV and a compact electric SUV.

IPO action intensifies: 11 cos target ₹7,055 cr next week

The rush reflects strong investor interest in early-stage growth firms

AGENCIES
New Delhi, September 6

India's primary market is set for another busy week, with 11 main-board companies, including Rentomojo, Karamtara Engineering and Kanohar Electricals, scheduled to raise a combined Rs 7,055 crore through IPOs between September 7 and 15. Most issues will open on Tuesday and Wednesday. YES Securities Chief Investment Officer Rajkumar Rathii said the rush reflects strong investor interest in



early-stage growth companies, with all 11 firms valued below \$1 billion at listing. Of the total mobilisation, Rs 2,722 crore, or 39 per cent, will come through fresh issues, while Rs 4,333 crore, or 61 per

CLOSER LOOK

- » Of the total mobilisation, Rs 2,722 crore, or 39 per cent, will come through fresh issues, while Rs 4,333 crore, or 61 per cent, will be raised through offers for sale (OFS)
- » Fresh capital will largely fund expansion, capital expenditure, debt repayment and working capital needs

cent, will be raised through offers for sale (OFS). Fresh capital will largely fund expansion, capex, debt repayment and working capital needs. Pranav Constructions will open its Rs 351-crore-plus IPO on September 7,

followed by Kanohar Electricals, Prasol Chemicals and Glass Wall Systems on September 8. Rentomojo, Manipal Payment and Identity Solutions, Arcil, LCC Projects, Karamtara Engineering and Steamhouse India will launch on Sep-

tember 9, while Veegaland Developers will open on September 10. Among the larger issues, Kanohar will raise Rs 1,056 crore, Rentomojo Rs 1,256 crore, Karamtara Rs 875 crore, Manipal Payment and Identity Solutions Rs 805 crore and Arcil Rs 733 crore. The IPO rush follows Rays of Belief and Deepa Jewellers, which launched on September 1. With the upcoming issues, the number of IPOs in 2026 is expected to reach 75, including 23 in August.

India qualify for AFC U20 Asian Cup

TASHKENT: India qualified for the AFC U20 Asian Cup main tournament for the first time in 20 years after a commanding 3-0 win over Bangladesh in their final group match of the qualifying event here on Sunday.

The win, their second in the qualifiers, took India to six points from three matches. They had to wait for the result of Syria vs Uzbekistan match played later on Sunday to know their fate.

With Syria losing 0-3 to Uzbekistan, India finished second in Group B and qualified for the AFC U20 Asian Cup main tournament after 20 years as one of the seven best runners-up teams across the eight groups. India last played in the AFC U20 Asian Cup main tournament in 2006. Uzbekistan also qualified as group toppers with nine points. Syria finished third with three points, and Bangladesh were relegated to the Development Phase.

BEAT CHINA'S HE JI TING AND REN XIANG YU

Satwik-Chirag clinch China Masters title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Shenzhen, September 6

Star Indian men's doubles pair of Satwicksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty produced a stirring comeback to beat China's He Ji Ting and Ren Xiang Yu in a three-game thriller and clinch the China Masters Super 750 title here on Sunday.

Playing their third final here, Satwik and Chirag, who finished runners-up in the 2023 and 2025 editions, fought their way to an 11-21 21-13 21-17 victory over former world No. 4 He and Ren in a one-hour and 10-minute battle.

"Playing here is always good. We have played here always after coming back from injury. I think in 2024, after the Olympics, we played here, we played semis. Then, last year, we played, we weren't in a good shape but we played finals," said Satwik after securing the 10th BWF World Tour victory of their career.

"This time also it is after coming back from injury, so I think this has been a tournament which gave us a lot of confidence. I



India's Chirag Shetty, front, and Satwicksairaj Rankireddy

AP/PTI

think this week has been the same story. Except the first round, I think all the games we have played three games.

"We made a game plan before coming. We wanted to do that. If it works, then it's good. If not, we'll go back and work again. So I think that has worked today, we kind of broke jinx and won second title in 2026, really happy."

It is the second title of the season for the Indians, who had won the Singapore Open Super 750, and reached the final of the Thailand Open Super 500.

The title is a big boost for the world No. 5 pair as they gear up to defend their gold medal at the Asian Games, scheduled to be held in Japan from September 19.

"It feels really special.

Obviously, going into the Asian Games, winning a title definitely gives a huge boost that yes, what we are working for is in the right direction," Chirag said.

"I think we will go back home, push ourselves to the limit, train for the next 10 days and go all guns blazing at the Asian Games. We want to go out there and have some fun."

Satwik and Chirag had defeated the Chinese pair twice in their only two previous meetings.

The Indian pair had played three three-game matches en route to the final, dropping the second game after winning the opening game in each of those encounters.

Playing their third final in their 10th tournament of the year, Satwik and Chirag opted to choose ends after winning the toss instead of receiving.

The Indians couldn't take early control of the rallies as He Ji Ting and Ren zoomed to a 5-0 lead with fast, attacking strokes in short and snappy exchanges.

They kept their serves tight and flat while maintaining an angled attack. A jump smash from He Ji Ting helped the Chinese pair maintain their five-point lead at 8-3.

The Indians tried to break through their rivals' defence, but the fast and aggressive Chinese pair took a six-point advantage into the interval. The Indians couldn't quite match the pace of their rivals as the deficit widened to 7-14.

Zheng Qinwen makes big US Open comeback

Osaka joins her in the 4th round

ASSOCIATED PRESS
New York, September 6

Zheng Qinwen was on her back with her arms in the air, celebrating a U.S. Open victory maybe only she believed was possible.

Madison Keys fought off tears as she tried to explain how Zheng, way down and all but out, somehow got the win.

Zheng, the Olympic gold medalist, extended her return to the U.S. Open on Saturday with a spectacular and stunning rally, winning the final seven games to eliminate No. 22 Keys 1-6, 7-6 (3), 7-5.

"I feel like I obviously got off to a really good lead, and then I just got really – I mean, got really scared, like I couldn't swing," Keys said. "I don't know. Tennis just feels really hard right now, so I feel like that kind of took over."

Hours later, 13th-seeded Naomi Osaka joined her in the fourth round by defeating Elise Mertens 6-3, 3-6, 7-5. The two-time champion from Japan put her head on her racket after the final point, stunned herself at the victory.



"Honestly, I can't believe I won this match," Osaka said. "I'm literally shocked that I won this match."

Not quite as big a comeback as Zheng, but Osaka was down 4-2 in the third set and apologized for expressing so much frustration throughout a tough night.

"There was a certain point, I don't know, I felt like I put my entire heart on the court and then I just kept trying every single point," Osaka said.

"I didn't feel like I played amazing, and it was really getting me down. I was very negative on myself."

Archery: India seal two VII medals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Ahmedabad, September 6

India were assured of at least two medals in the Visually Impaired 1 category after Yugal Garg, Pawan Kumar and Tanvi Ingale advanced to the semifinals on the second day of the third stage of the World Archery Para Series,

here on Sunday.

The strong showing in the VII event came along with a dominant qualification display by India's compound archers, with world No. 1 and reigning world champion Sheetal Devi topping the women's standings and the Indian men's and women's teams secur-

ing top seeding. Sheetal, the armless Indian para archer from Jammu, shot 698 out of a possible 720 to claim the top seed in the women's compound qualification.

Four Indians advanced to the second round of 16, with Lalpati seeded 11th, Sarita 12th and Payal Nag 14th.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Chennai, September 6

Skipper Ishan Kishan struck a flowing unbeaten 111, leading East Zone to a commanding 385 for four against a sloppy South Zone on the opening day of the Duleep Trophy final here on Sunday.

Kishan (14x4, 1x6) and

Kumar Kushagra (63) were batting at stumps, and the fifth wicket pair has so far added 144 runs in just 26.4 overs.

The other contributors were teen phenom Vaibhav Sooryavanshi (44, 37b), Abhimanyu Easwaran (72), and Shikhar Mohan (85).

Kishan, who com-

pleted 4000 first-class runs, merged aggression and composure to a nicety in his 135-ball knock, and raised 94 runs for the fourth wicket with Mohan.

It came at an important juncture too when East were in trouble, the only time in the first innings so far, at 147 for three.

South could have had their rivals in a far deeper predicament but Kishan and Mohan averted the disaster on a pitch that remained true the whole day.

Kishan's was a complete innings, sending the ball to all parts of the field through powerful pulls and imperious drives

through the covers.

The left-hander reached his fifty in 71 balls and then the next 50 came off 51 balls, completing his 10th first-class hundred.

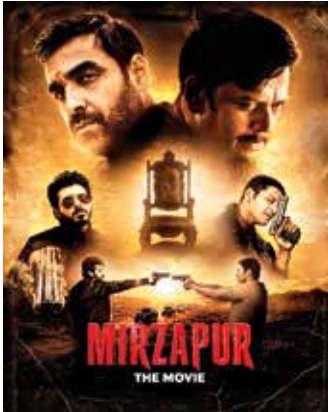
Kishan reached the landmark with a driven four off Shreyas Gopal, who was playing in his 100th first-class match.

FILM



'DIDN'T EXPECT PEOPLE WOULD FEEL SO MUCH FOR SWEETY'

Actress
Shriya
Pilgaonkar
returns as
Sweety in
'Mirzapur:
The Movie'



THE FILM MARKS THE FIRST BIG-SCREEN OUTING FOR THE 'MIRZAPUR' UNIVERSE

MUMBAI: It all felt like a big party, said Shriya Pilgaonkar, who returns as Sweety in 'Mirzapur: The Movie', the cinematic extension of her popular crime series 'Mirzapur' and she hopes that fans will be as welcoming of the film as they have been of the show.

The film, which made its debut in cinema halls across the country on September 4, marks the first big-screen outing for the 'Mirzapur' universe, which began as a streaming series in 2018 and went on to become one of India's most successful

OTT franchises over the course of three seasons.

Pilgaonkar, who has reprised her role as Swaragini 'Sweety' Gupta, the love interest of Ali Fazal's gun-toting gangster Guddu Pandit, from the show's first season, called the movie an 'experiment'.

"I hope it does well. We've no idea how it will be received, but there's anticipation, there's love. For me, coming back to it after season one and reuniting with the cast has felt like a party. So, I'm going to enjoy watching it on the big screen,"

she told PTI in an interview.

'Mirzapur: The Movie' brings back the lawless world of 'Mirzapur', where the battle for power continues amid a barrage of bullets, betrayals and bloody rivalries. The movie is set in 2018, hinting at an untold chapter from the first season of the show.

Besides Pilgaonkar and Fazal, the movie also brings back the show's core cast, which includes Pankaj Tripathi as Kaleen Bhaiya, Divyendu as Munna Tripathi, Rasika Dugal as Beena Tripathi, Shweta Tripathi

as Gajamani 'Golu' Gupta and Abhishek Banerjee as Subodh alias Compounder.

Though her character was killed in the season one finale, Pilgaonkar said the affection audiences have continued to show towards Sweety has always stayed with her. "I didn't expect that people would feel so much for Sweety. That is the love that has carried us through. I can confidently tell you that just the love that 'Mirzapur' has received will keep me going. That's how sweet and loyal the fans are," she said.

PTI

Kunal shares about casting Preity in 'Vibe'

Zinta essays the role of an undercover agent

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Mumbai, September 6

Amazon MGM Studios' unveiled the much-awaited trailer of its upcoming high-stakes action comedy 'VIBE', headlined by Kunal Kemmu. Following the massive buzz around the teaser, the makers have now raised the stakes with an explosive and power-packed trailer that promises a thrilling ride filled with chaos, action, humour and unexpected twists. While the film also features Preity Zinta, Kunal Kemmu shared the idea of casting her in an undercover agent's role.

Kunal revealed how a scene from the film, featuring Preity Zinta revealing her real identity as an undercover agent, sparked an idea in his mind to cast the actress.

While sharing this interesting process, Kunal said, "So, when I came to this character, I was genuinely thinking about who and what it would be. In my mind, I'm also a big Preity Zinta fan. So, what happens is, when that woman comes in, she's Preity Zinta. And people say, 'Preity Zinta, she's an undercover agent'. And Zinta says, 'What did you think? I got married and went to America; this is my life. I'm actually a government agent'. So, this thought came to my mind, but of course, I didn't carry on with that thought. But when I finished writing this film and then it came to casting this, I had never



this. So, it'll be the best casting. Now, all I need to do is get her to say yes. So, that's how the journey started. But I'm very happy that she agreed to do this film. And I think she looks lovely as Marimatch."

'VIBE' stars Kunal Kemmu alongside Preity G Zinta, Sparsh Shrivastava and debutant Vanshika Dhir in lead roles and it'll hit theatres on September 18.

seen her acting before. No one would have expected